

George Douglas Papers family reading edition

Volume VII

Folder 6 correspondence

Version 2.0

September 2026

Prepared for Volney Douglas

From scans supplied by Abilene Christian University

Special Collections and Archives

A readable version in plain English, with uncertainties and damaged passages marked.

This volume accounts for all 134 scan pages of source 09. It belongs to a set covering 932 scan pages in ten source PDFs. This AI-assisted contribution is offered for review and correction.

Reading this volume

Preparation and independence

Prepared for Volney Douglas with AI assistance in September 2026. Every new scan page received an initial visual reading, with selected enlargement, rotation, contrast adjustment and comparison against related passages within the source collection. Local Apple Vision OCR was run at four orientations on all 545 new pages as a reading aid. OCR agreement alone did not establish a reading. The other agent's transcription was excluded as a source for this addition. Reference and family readings of the new pages were prepared together from the scans; they are not independent of each other. No independent human verification or ACU endorsement is claimed. The earlier version 1.1 has its own disclosed comparison history, preserved in the previous guide and review records.

Reference and family editions

The annotated reference edition preserves readable original wording, spelling, grammar and abbreviations. Ordinary prose wrapping may be reflowed; poem lines and ledger groups are retained. Capitalization, punctuation and word division sometimes require judgment. Superscripts are generally lowered; raised numbers in the convivial journal are retained. Underlining and decorative marks are not systematically encoded. This is a direct reading transcript, not a facsimile or fully diplomatic edition. The family edition modernizes wording and explains abbreviated forms where secure. Very damaged passages sometimes receive an explicitly identified fragmentary reading rather than an invented continuous text. Financial figures remain as read and are not silently reconciled.

Uncertainty and interventions

Double square brackets identify editorial intervention. `[[word?]]` is a tentative reading; `[[illegible]]` marks unread writing, with no implied word count. `[[lost: description]]` records missing material and `[[obscured: description]]` records an obstruction. `[[deleted: text]]` and `[[inserted: text]]` distinguish readable revisions. `[[separate block: description]]`, `[[blank]]` and other descriptive markers explain layout or non-textual material. Original single brackets and question marks remain part of the source. A gap is not filled solely to make a fluent sentence or to match a related copy.

Order and evidence

The reference volumes retain PDF scan order. Editorial notes link displaced continuations and clearer related versions. The family edition also retains source-page locators, with reading-order guidance beside the relevant text. Later identifying slips remain distinct from the manuscript and may disagree with it. A name in an account does not establish kinship, ownership or parentage. Poems may use fictional speakers, aliases, satire and imagined events. Letters preserve their writers' assertions, rumors and opinions, including offensive historical language; a transcript does not verify those statements.

Locators and corrections

A page ID such as 09-003 means source 09, PDF scan page 3, counting the cover as page 1. A block ID such as 09-003-P02 identifies the second transcript block. These locators are not original manuscript page numbers. Earlier IDs are unchanged. New uncertainty IDs append U001, U002 and so on to their source-page ID. Please propose corrections with the locator, existing wording, proposed wording and supporting image evidence. The original scans remain authoritative.

Source credit

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Source record

George Douglas Papers Folder 6 - Correspondence.pdf

SHA-256: c7d09095adfe8a5111474596c93a759be128b5efcd3fef5a9a942b77377862a3

Scan 001 09-001

University cover sheet: Folder 6, Correspondence

Abilene Christian University, Digital Commons @ ACU. George Douglas Papers, Folder 6: Correspondence. The repository cover gives 1863 as its catalog date and places the collection among digitized manuscripts, personal papers, and archival records. Subjects listed: Christianity, genealogy, military history, social history, and United States history. Collection address: https://digitalcommons.acu.edu/george_douglas.

Scan 002 09-002

Rebecca Goodloe to her daughter Mary, April 18, 1852

Rutherford County, Tennessee, April 18, 1852. Dear daughter, Your letter and Rebecca's, dated October 18, 1851, arrived in good time. I would have answered, but expected another once Mr. Andrews reached you. I have waited all this time without receiving one. You ask me to write often. I know how glad I am to receive a letter, and it warms my heart to hear from you all. I am glad Susanna was baptized. I hope she will do good, be generous and ready to share, building a foundation for eternal life, as the passage in Timothy says. My sister Betsey died on January 26. She suffered greatly and was *[[“tapt” seven times?—word uncertain]]*. For nine days she lived on a little snow and melted snow; it was all she wanted. She was ready to die. Heavy snow fell on January 18. I visited whenever I could and was with her when she died. John Cock told me that everyone was well except Mr. Douglass. I am sorry he is ill and hope he can care for himself and recover. I do not know how you manage where everything is so scarce and expensive. Please tell me whether the things I sent with Mr. Andrews were damaged during *[[“cashing,” meaning uncertain]]*, and whether the peafowl feathers arrived safely.

Scan 003 09-003

Weaving, gardening, household work, and neighborhood news

Give my sincere regards to Mr. and Mrs. Andrew for their kindness and generosity. I hope they like their new country, prosper in this life, and find happiness in the next. Rebecca asks what became of all the girls who married after she left. I cannot tell her everything; I think some would have been better off single. Isabella Hill moved to the western district. She had a daughter, Rhoda Louisa, and I heard her health was poor when she left.

Now for my own affairs. Thank God, I am reasonably healthy. I can get about and manage business, knit, sew, card wool or cotton, and do some spinning on the little wheel. I bought a loom, and Mary has woven *[[number unclear: “2” followed by another figure]]* lengths of cloth this winter. That is better than having my weaving done elsewhere. I have been gardening: peas are up and supported; Irish potatoes and onions are growing; beans and okra are planted; and beets, cucumbers, peppers, and cabbage plants are growing. We have planted some corn and will plant cotton this week. Mary tends the crop and garden with Sam.

Judy has a baby boy named Jim, said to be three months old. She does the cooking and washing. Amanda is at Betsey Graham's; I do not know whether I can spare her from the crop. Alfred arranged for William Arbuckil to take Tom for the year in return for food and clothing and to teach him to work efficiently. Bill is here, carrying water and watching the children. Enough about that.

Scan 004 09-004

Family marriages and moves; signed Mother Rebecca Goodloe

Cousin Betsey Adams, Billy Adams's widow, has moved here and rented the *[[Gonnatya?]]* house from Mr. Hall. I let her boys farm some land. Her son Billy works at the sawmill and gristmill. Brother Jacob bought the mills from Ned Adam and is doing good business. He is busy as a bee, building a bridge.

Everyone at home is well; Rebecca and Anda Alexander are well too.

Granville Jetton married Miss Elizabeth *[[Conn?]]*. Dick Jones married his third wife, Miss Mary, Elder McHenry's daughter. Mary Waight has married Sam Rucker. Mary Goodloe remains helpless and was worse when I last heard. William Goodloe moved to Trenton, Gibson County, in the western district.

Henry Goodloe's daughters Altamira and Emily went along to spend the summer with relatives. James Goodloe married Miss Ann Neal of Gibson County and lives in Trenton.

Rebecca asked about Ned Adams and Cousin Betsey. They are well and doing better, although their little girl, one of the twins, has died. I cannot remember half the news Rebecca wants. Cousin Livve Posey and everyone in my family are well except Hannah, who is frail and has severe spells of illness. Betsey bought a house and lot in Woodbury with her own money and has the deed in her name.

Polly, just here Alfred arrived with your long-awaited letter. I read it with great satisfaction. I began this letter on Sunday, added to it yesterday, and now it is Tuesday. I was nearly finished when Alfred came.

Julie is staying with Betsey in Woodbury. Your loving mother, Rebecca Goodloe. To Mary Douglass.

Scan 005 09-005

Rebecca Goodloe to her granddaughter Susannah, April 21, 1852

Wednesday, April 21. Dear Susannah,

I was nearly done writing when your grateful letter arrived. It gave me great pleasure and comfort. Thank you, dear granddaughter. I hope you will always remember me as your grandmother. Your letter was very good; I did not know you could write so well. I am sorry your father is ill. I would almost urge him to try a water treatment if he knew how to use it, though he must judge for himself.

The remedy I describe for cramping colic is a blanket dipped in hot water and wrung out, wrapped around the person with more warm blankets or a featherbed, and heated rocks or boiled corn at the feet and shoulders to bring on sweating. I mention this for your mother, who used to suffer from colic.

Write again and tell me what everyone is doing. Give Rebecca my love and ask her to write as soon as this arrives. Tell the boys to write too. My love to all the family. I will try to write again; the others here must write for themselves. That is all I can do now. Your affectionate grandmother, Rebecca Goodloe. To Susannah Douglass.

Hannah was very glad to hear from you all.

Reading note. The water and heat treatments are reproduced solely as historical content, not present-day medical advice.

Scan 006 09-006

S. J. Goodloe reports his mother's death, June 18, 1852

Woodbury, Cannon County, Tennessee, June 18, 1852. Mr. N. L. Douglas,

Dear Sir, I understand Lewis Jetton wrote about Mother's death, but did not describe the circumstances of that sudden and sorrowful event. My dear mother is gone. She died on May 6, nearly seventy years old.

She faced life's hardships with patience and Christian conduct, reaching a standard of integrity, morality,

and faith that few attain. At last she rests peacefully in the grave, ready, in our faith, to rise to heaven in God's eternal kingdom on the morning of resurrection.

Scan 007 09-007

The sudden collapse on May 6

On the morning of May 6, she got up apparently as well as usual and managed household business normally. Late that evening, while sewing trousers, she suddenly fell from her chair, as though paralyzed. *[[Jena?]]*, a Black girl and the only other person in the room, helped her to bed. Mother called Julia when she fell, but Julia was occupied in another room and did not initially think it serious. Julia arrived about the time Mother reached the bed. When asked how she felt, Mother said she was very ill and seemed dazed. Her symptoms suggested what the writer called apoplexy. She soon seemed better, although at times her words showed lapses of memory. I had been—

Scan 008 09-008

Her final half-hour and those present

—away all day. I returned just before sunset, and Julia told me Mother was sick. At her bedside I asked what was wrong. She said her stomach was upset and her eyes and head hurt, though she felt better. I left the room; about ten minutes later Julia called that Mother was dying. I hurried back and saw that she was close to death. About half an hour later she was gone. She scarcely struggled and clasped my hand as though saying goodbye. She had not spoken since telling me she felt better.

The writer lists *[[Jena?]]*, Hannah, and himself as those of the family present; some nearby neighbors were also there. Hannah grieves deeply and is in poor health. Julia, Hannah, and Alfred will stay on the farm—

Scan 009 09-009

S. J. Goodloe's signature and the household's plans

—until the harvest is gathered; then they will separate. Julia and Hannah will live with either Sister Rebecca or Betsey. Give my love to all the family. Yours as ever, S. J. Goodloe.

Postscript: Our relatives are generally well. S. J. G.

The folded letter is addressed to Mr. N. L. Douglas, Esquire, Red Oak Post Office, Ellis County, Texas.

An endorsement reads "Woodbury Tenn, 21st June"; another identifies it as S. J. Goodloe's account of his mother's death.

Scan 010 09-010

Wrapper identifying Rebecca Goodloe's letters and Emily Douglas's song

This wrapper describes three items: Rebecca Goodloe's October 6, 1851 letter to her daughter Mary Douglas; an undated song or ballad written by Emily Douglas; and Sam J. Goodloe's account of the death of his mother, Rebecca Goodloe.

Scan 011 09-011

Rebecca sends cloth and clothing to Polly, October 6, 1851

October 6, 1851. Dear Polly,

I hope everyone is well. Thank God, I am as well as usual. Hannah is still unwell; walking about and smoking her pipe are all she does.

News from the western district: Mr. Nance has a fever, while Lucy and four children have chills and fever. Cynthia and her whole family have been sick. Your brother Sam is attending law school in Lebanon. We have heard nothing from Mobile since last spring. My sister Betsey Woods is very ill with dropsy. Last Thursday four gallons of fluid were drained from her, relieving her suffering somewhat, but I do not expect her to recover. The Andrews family will bring you all the news.

I am sending cloth with Mr. Andrews for you to use as you think best. I hope Mr. Douglas and Warren will have coats if they wish. There are twenty-two yards of jeans fabric in the trunk. I intended the green for George's coat and trousers. I could not get it all dyed. The weaver, Martha Ann *[[goad?]]* Adams, hurried to finish because John wanted to move to Arkansas. I suggest walnut bark and a little copperas to dye George's trousers black, since the last piece is uneven in color. There are thirteen yards of dark brown and five of pale brown. I am also sending summer cloth for Jesse's and Warren's trousers, and eight and a half yards of plaid for the little girls' winter dresses. There are yarn socks for Mr. Douglass, cotton stockings for you and Laura, little blue ones for Mary, and yarn to knit—

Scan 012 09-012

Seeds, quills, baptisms, and a marriage rumor

—stockings for the other children. I am sending Rebecca eight yards of calico. If that is not enough for her dress, she should give it to Susanna. I am sending cotton dresses for Susanna and Laura, and three and a half yards of blue checked calico for little Mary. If that will not make a dress, use it for something else. There are peafowl feathers, goose quills, sage, garden comfrey seed I grew myself, and a little starch. I am sorry to burden Mr. Andrew, but he willingly does what he can for Mr. Douglass, whom he calls a great friend. Give my love to Jesse, Henry, and everyone else, and accept the same yourself. Your mother, Rebecca Goodloe.

We had a four- or five-day meeting at Riplecreek Meetinghouse. Brothers Trot and Corlee preached, as did *[[Sanda?]]* Jones. Fourteen were baptized; the list includes John Smith, *[[Eveart and Houghs?]]*, two of Nathan Hale's daughters, and *[[Polenna?]]* Jones. Emily Goodloe and Altamira had been baptized earlier. I cannot write any more now. Write as often as possible, and ask Rebecca and Susanna to write whenever they can send mail. I nearly forgot: I heard Sarah Barr is going to marry.

To Mary Douglass. The braid is to trim Susanna's green sack jacket; put two rows around it.

Scan 013 09-013

The Pleasures of Memory: an unsigned essay

The Pleasures of Memory

How often our thoughts return to the pleasures of earlier days, formed before we knew the cares of the world—memories that time cannot erase.

Life's worries often weigh on us until we see nothing bright. Then a familiar sound or a clear, musical voice suddenly stirs our hearts and returns us to a treasured scene.

We remember loved ones at home, whose hands cared for us and whose guidance led us through life's uneven paths.

Scan 014 09-014

Memories of home, prairie flowers, and streams

We remember home, that sacred place where we spent our happiest hours:

No matter how bleak the place,
How grand or humble the home,
Love keeps bonds that never die
And ties our hearts to home.

We remember its surroundings and the hours spent wandering the broad prairies gathering colorful flowers. That was then the height of our ambitions. We delighted in following the moss-covered banks of nearby streams, forgetting how quickly time passed.

Scan 015 09-015

Sunday-school memories and the comfort of remembrance

Think of the later pleasure of being old enough for Sunday school: the happiness of entering the room, gathering eagerly around the teacher, and learning from the Bible.

Children look into the teacher's face with complete trust, and the lessons leave a lasting impression.

Those scenes remain in my memory. I imagine that near the end of life we can still say:

There are moments in life we never forget,
Growing brighter as time slips away;
They add new delight to our happiest days,
And bring light to our loneliest day.

Scan 016 09-016

Patriotic Song, bearing Emily Douglas's name

Patriotic Song

Of all the lands in east or west,
I love my native country best.
It overflows with God's good gifts.
Though neither gold nor gems are found,
People with noble hearts abound,
And eyes shine brightly with joy. [Repeat.]

Of all the tongues in east or west,
I love my native language best.
It may not be so smoothly spoken,
Or woven with Italian skill,
But when heart speaks to heart,
Its word is never broken. [Repeat.]

Of all the peoples east or west,
I love my countrymen the best,

A people of a noble spirit.
 A sober mind, a generous heart,
 Taught goodness, free from artifice,
 They inherit *[[from?]]* their ancestors. [Repeat.]

I offer my hand to all the world,
 But give my heart to my native land,
 Seeking its good and glory.
 I honor every nation's name,
 Respect its fortune and its fame,
 But love the land that bore me. [Repeat.]

Emily Douglas.

[[A partly unreadable practice line also appears between stanzas.]]

Scan 017 09-017

Columbus, Mississippi, envelope to Mary Douglass

Addressed to Mrs. Mary Douglass, Red Oak Post Office, Ellis County, Texas. Postmarked Columbus, Mississippi, October 30. The accompanying letter is dated October 24, 1855.

Scan 018 09-018

Miriam Stevenson reconnects with Polly from Columbus, October 24, 1855

Columbus, October 24, 1855. Mrs. Douglas, my dear old friend,
 This evening I am finally doing what I have long wished: writing to you. Until recently I did not know your address. I have just returned from Tennessee, our old home, where I learned where you live. Mrs. Sam Davis passed along a message from her husband. I was delighted to hear that you are doing well and have good prospects. I wish you a long, happy life; no one cares more deeply about you and your family. Polly—as I am used to calling you—we have both faced many troubles since we parted. I believe they work for our good if we love the Lord. I have learned that earthly things pass away. This is not my permanent home; I look toward the city built by God. My heart and treasure are there, and I have no reason to complain. I am healthy and weigh 144.

In Tennessee I saw your sisters, Mrs. Jones and Mrs. Nance. Doca was visiting and looks very thin, as does Julia. I did not see—

Scan 019 09-019

Changes in Tennessee and Miriam's life after her husband's death

—Rebecca or Betsey, because I could not conveniently visit, though I heard they were well. I saw many old neighbors and new people too. Mary Weather*[[s?]]*, for instance, has seven daughters! Even the countryside seems strange; few people or things looked familiar.

Rebecca Alexander looks well, but Andy looks unwell. Uncle Jacob and Aunt Polly look much aged, although they worry as much as ever about worldly affairs. There are too many changes to recount. Sister Louisa wrote this morning that Virginia McKnight, formerly Johnson, died. She visited her mother on Sunday, became ill that night, and died on Thursday. Sister Lou lives comfortably and produces plenty for her needs. During a short stop in Murfreesboro, I saw Aunt Brown, Amanda Mosby, Dora Brown, and Dora Nance together, but could not stay to hear much news.

As for me, I still teach and try to be useful. I kept house for two and a half years—the happiest period of my life. After my husband died, I stopped keeping my own household. He had four children. His relatives took three, and I kept one: a sweet girl named Virginia, now almost ten.

Scan 020 09-020

Teaching, raising Virginia, and maintaining old friendships

My chief concern is to raise and educate her. She is advanced for her age. I have enough money to support us without working, but I prefer employment because it is good for health and happiness. For several years I have boarded at a hotel, so I have little to do besides attend school and church. We have a pleasant church building and meet every Sunday to worship according to the Bible.

Mr. Darnall, Elizabeth, and Eveline have recently had chills, but they live nearby and are doing well. Thomas Sherrill also lives here and is one of the best artists *[[words obscured]]*. If this letter reaches you, I will send an example of his work as a keepsake with my next letter. Please write a long reply soon. Remember me to anyone in the family who recalls me. Surely Mr. Douglass has not forgotten me; tell him I would be delighted to receive a letter. *[[Unclear fragment.]]*

A fond farewell. Yours sincerely, Miriam Stevenson.

Scan 021 09-021

Miriam sends her portrait, March 29, 1856

Columbus, March 29, 1856. Dearest Mrs. Douglass,

After a long delay I gladly acknowledge your welcome letter. The cold, unpleasant winter made the mail irregular. Now that the weather is better, I will venture to send my portrait. I do not think it important to anyone, but I want to remain in your memory. Perhaps you have forgotten exactly how I look; if so, it will recall earlier days. Here I am in my forty-eighth year, weighing 145 and feeling as young as nineteen.

I am healthy except for occasional neuralgia, that fashionable complaint, which ties me in knots. I still teach, but think this may be my last term. I am tired of being confined. I would love to travel if I were braver, but water and steam make me very nervous.

Scan 022 09-022

An enduring friendship and news from Sister Lou

I am delighted that you and your children are well. They are dear to me because they are yours. I would love to see everyone, though I cannot promise I ever will. Neither time nor absence can erase the happy memories of our youth; they remain fresh places in my memory that distance cannot destroy.

Sister Lou wrote recently that your cousin Tompson Wright married Miss *[[Bowen?]]*, and that Virginia McKnight, William's wife, died. Everyone here is well and sends greetings. Tell Mr. Douglass I value his kindness and return his good wishes fourfold.

My love to my dear cousins James and Cynthie. I remember them fondly and hope they remember me. Write soon. My best wishes go with you and your family. Farewell, dear friend. May the Lord protect you through life, comfort you in death, and receive you in heaven. Your friend, Miriam Stevenson.

Scan 023 09-023

Envelope to Mary at Pleasant Run, Dallas County

To Mrs. Mary Douglass, Pleasant Run, Dallas County, Texas, from Miriam Stevenson. Postmarked Columbus, Mississippi, March 31; associated letter dated March 29, 1856.

Scan 024 09-024

Miriam describes the portrait's dress and hairstyle, July 6, 1856

Columbus, July 6, 1856. My dear friend Mrs. Douglas,
Your letter of May 26 arrived safely and was warmly welcomed. I was amused that you thought there might have been a mistake with the picture. I assure you it is me! I wore a mohair headdress with three curls on each side. My dress was rich blue-and-brown brocade, but the colors did not show in the picture. I am glad to hear of your health and prospects. I pray you have a long, useful, happy life, and that I may see you again. What a pleasant thought! But we must not presume upon the future; only the present is ours. Remembering our happy hours together saddens me because they cannot return. Still, we should not let memories of the past darken the future.

I am fairly well and will soon spend two months in the country. The hot season is unpleasant here—

Scan 025 09-025

Country air and religious fellowship

—and it will be lovely to breathe the country air. I long to go. After ten months of being closely confined, I am free again.

I have just returned from church and will finish the letter. Our preacher was sick, so there was no sermon, but we observe our worship practices whether a preacher is present or not. We never neglect that. If everyone valued their religious freedom, Christians would gather to sing, praise, and give thanks, rejoicing in the Lord's commands.

For me, this is life's greatest pleasure. I owe much to God for his kindness, especially since I moved south, where circumstances have favored my Christian life. You know that earlier I was persecuted, shunned, and mocked for my beliefs and practices. Yet I have always rejoiced—and still do—that I may share in the suffering of the one who suffered so much for me.

Scan 026 09-026

Miriam responds to Mary's discouragement

You sounded discouraged in your last letter. I fear you give too much weight to worldly troubles. You wrote that the days of your pilgrimage had been few and unhappy. Do not let such thoughts intrude. You have, I believe, a very kind husband and children who have never disgraced you. Reflect again, and you will find countless reasons for gratitude instead of complaint.

I fear you may not have surrendered fully to God's guidance. Without that, I believe, you cannot expect peace. Do not take this to mean I consider you a great sinner—no! I mean you must belong to Christ's body. Attend to that, my friend, and secure your place in heaven.

Please write again; your letters give me great pleasure. I hope to send you a present when the opportunity comes. Give Mr. Douglass my affection *[[the original modifier is uncertain]]*, respect, and esteem, and remember me to the children who recall me.

Scan 027 09-027

Miriam's closing greeting to James and Cynthia

Tell Cousin James and Cynthia that I care deeply about their well-being. I hope they live like Zachariah and Elizabeth. May knowledge of the truth bring increasing peace. Yours in hope, M. Stevenson.

Scan 028 09-028

W. Douglas to his sister Rebecca, June 3, 1856

Wardville, June 3, 1856. Dear Sister,

I was delighted to receive your letter of May 20. At first I was a little surprised—then surprised at my own surprise. What could be more natural than for us to think of one another and write often? It is surprising we have not done so before. I could never forget you or love you less as time and circumstances change. Every memory of my past is inseparably connected with you.

As far back as I can remember, you were my constant and almost only childhood playmate. Through boyhood, youth, and adulthood, you remained my companion. How could we ever lose our warm, lasting affection?

Other relationships may form and other friendships fade, but ours is woven into our lives—an affection *[[the following image about roots and clay is uncertain]]*.

I am well. There is little else to report about myself, since nothing happens that would interest you—

Scan 029 09-029

Why he wants to leave Texas for California

—in these hard times. Spring was very wet, but now we have had three dry weeks and badly need rain. The corn looks fairly promising; wheat is doing poorly here.

Henry's letter came with yours. He was well, but business is slow for him too. Like me, he seems uncertain about his future.

You sound horrified by my idea of going to California. I do not think you need to be. Other men—better men than your brother—are there or going there. Every intelligent person I have spoken to who has seen California speaks highly of it. Many urge me to go; some are returning with their families.

I cannot get beyond a hand-to-mouth existence in Texas without being extremely strict in business and spending. Neither suits my nature or my outlook. Why should I feel so tied to Texas when I am already effectively and hopelessly separated from you and everyone else who loves me?

If there is a better place, why not find it? Why not enjoy the best this little world offers, when even its best is poor enough? I do not expect sudden—

Reading note. “Your brother” explains the unusual phrase “men, & better than yours”; it is a contextual interpretation, not an added name. His California journey remains a plan in this letter.

Scan 030 09-030

Preparations for California and a proposed visit

—wealth from moving, but I think I can do better there. I have considered it for a long time, and it is worth going even if only to discover that I was mistaken. You can be fairly certain I will go to California in the spring, if I live. I have already begun making arrangements.

District Court opens here Monday, and I must testify in a land case. If nothing intervenes, I will visit immediately afterward, though business may prevent it. Uncle Lewis and the others were well when I last

heard. My regards to Norvell and all friends who ask after me.
 Truly your brother, W. Douglas. To Rebecca Winnifrid.
 Write often. Your letters will always give me fresh pleasure. W. D.

Scan 031 09-031

Condolences on George's father's death, July 9, probably 1874

Corinth, Mississippi, July 9, *[[1874?]]*. Cousin George,
 I have received your June 23 letter with the sad news of your father's death. We were very sorry, though at his advanced age it was to be expected in the natural course of life. Those of us still living are well and doing well. Sister Marthah died last August. *[[Ma?]]* has been healthier this year than for several years. About the *[[unclear financial matter]]*, I never meant any of you to worry. I thought I had written that several times. Give the amount to Aunt Polly and Cousin Lizzie; if that does not settle matters, write again. We have a good crop. I have been hoeing cotton today and feel little like writing, which explains this short letter and poor handwriting.
 Please write a long letter describing the country, its changes, the railroad routes, and land prices. Love to everyone. Yours, E. M. Hyneman.

Scan 032 09-032

Corinth envelope to George Douglas at Red Oak

To George Douglas, Red Oak, Texas. Postmarked Corinth, Mississippi, July 9. Handwritten name: Ott V. Hyneman. A faint annotation includes N. L. Douglas; the remainder is unreadable. The adjacent letter is signed E. M. Hyneman.

Scan 033 09-033

A badly faded letter about the war's end, May 15, 1865

[[Ship Island?]], May 15, 1865. Dear Cousin George,
[[Much of the opening is unreadable. It mentions an answer to a letter, W. T. followed by an unreadable name, and Jones.]]
[[The writer discusses events threatening to ruin the country. The connected wording is lost.]] The sooner the better for us. *[[Unclear passage.]]* Most of the troops are leaving everywhere. *[[Unclear wording about disgust.]]* We have no government now. All the prisoners *[[unreadable continuation]]*.
[[A largely unreadable passage mentions a fort, "yesterday," and a colonel who does not know something.]] I have heard several *[[unreadable reports]]* about the armies of *[[Johnston?]]*, but we cannot hear the truth. *[[The remaining lines are too faint for a reliable connected reading; Saturday and Saturday morning are mentioned. The sentence continues on the next page.]]*

Reading note. This is a fragmentary reading of a severely faded page. The location and military references remain tentative, and the missing text has not been reconstructed from historical expectations.

Scan 034 09-034

Surrender news and hopes of home: faded continuation

[[The sentence discusses General Lee's surrender and Johnson, but the connection is unreadable.]] I will *[[unreadable]]* be home soon.
 George, if we are disbanded *[[unreadable continuation about the country]]*. *[[The writer mentions getting*

a wife, then says that she must have “the piles,” with the explanation unreadable.]] A nice young widow will do *[[unreadable continuation]]*.

George, I could *[[unreadable]]* write *[[unreadable]]*. Your cousin Rebecca *[[unreadable]]*. After I get my *[[unreadable]]*, to Texas *[[unreadable]]*. If I can get the chance, I will *[[unreadable]]*.

[[Love and an apology follow, with missing words.]] Write soon. Regards to *[[unreadable]]*. Yours, *[[A. H. Hyneman?]]*.

Reading note. Only surviving fragments can be offered responsibly. This page needs further examination of the original or a better scan for a continuous reading.

Scan 035 09-035

Arthur Hyneman's envelope to Lizzie Douglas

Envelope numbered 3, addressed to Miss Lizzie Douglas, Red Oak, Ellis County, Texas. Annotation: From Arthur Hyneman; a following place-name is partly unreadable, ending “Miss.”

Scan 036 09-036

Arthur Hyneman's unfinished letter from Corinth

Corinth, Mississippi, September *[[16?]]*, *[[1869?]]*. My very dear cousin,

After a long delay, I have decided to answer my darling cousin's letter. Do not think my affection has diminished; I have been busy. If I did not know how forgiving you are, I would have long ago concluded that you thought me inconsiderate. It is a great pleasure to answer your letters.

The family is well. *[[Some wording is unclear.]]* Cholera is all around us, and almost everyone who catches it dies very quickly. I hope we escape it. Corinth is rather dull. We have excellent crops and *[[unclear wording]]* wonderful watermelons, but they are almost gone now. I do not know what I will do; there is no fruit in the country. I suppose it is for the best.

How is my Texan *[[name or description unreadable]]*? All right, I hope.

There will be a grand tournament here on the fifteenth of next month. I expect it to be enjoyable. It is time we had something to break the town's monotony, since we have had—*[[continuation not present on this page]]*.

Scan 037 09-037

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Scan 038 09-038

Cousin Dilla writes about illness and family news

Corinth, Mississippi, November 28, *[[1869?]]*. My dear cousin,

Thank you again for your welcome letter. I had begun to think you had forgotten your own cousin Dilla. *[[Damaged wording.]]* Hearing from my friends gives me great pleasure. *[[Tape hides much of the next passage.]]*

[[Someone's health is discussed.]] Frank also had a severe *[[unreadable illness]]*, but everyone is well now. Ma has suffered for *[[unclear duration]]* months with a swelling or sore on her foot and has not worn a shoe for some time. I hope it soon heals.

I have little news that would interest you, since you do not know our area or its people. Things are livelier

than in summer. Money is scarce and food prices are high, but my brothers always manage to raise *[[damaged continuation]]*.

[[Someone]] is very unkind, or something *[[damaged]]*, and could have answered my last letter. I am always glad to receive her kind letters. I wish I could see her; I know she is a dear, good girl. *[[Damaged words about love to everyone and someone being kept hard at work. The sentence continues on the next page.]]*

Scan 039 09-039

Dilla's chores, Uncle D, and cousin Lizzie

—poor little Dill has to get up, make breakfast, and milk the cows. Don't you feel sorry for me? Of course you do!

[[Damaged passage about Laura.]] How is she, and what is she doing? Since she married she seems not to care about anyone—just as you would be! Pa asks Uncle D to write a long letter; *[[the wording about its intended recipient is unclear]]*. It would be a pleasure to know it was written in his own hand. Daddy *[[unreadable words]]* says he is working hard and beginning to look old.

[[A passage about Brother Jack, returning, and Atlanta is partly hidden by tape and cannot be reconstructed reliably.]]

Tell Cousin Lizzie not to neglect me. *[[Damaged wording about affection.]]* I think we ought to be together. Love to everyone. Ever your cousin, Dilla.

Don't forget to write soon. Dilla.

Scan 040 09-040

A. D. Ott describes his children and schooling, October 28, 1859

Murfreesboro, Tennessee, October 28, 1859. *[[Opening damaged.]]* Uncle,

After neglecting to write for a long time, I am sitting down to let you know I have not forgotten you. I wrote earlier; I suppose the letter never arrived, or you would have answered.

My family is well. It is a large family: I have five girls and one boy with Jane. *[[Damaged words.]]* The older one turns twenty-one on December 27, and the other is nineteen. Both attend *[[damaged word, apparently college]]* in Murfreesboro. William finishes at the beginning of December. Both belong to the college literary society and rank highly as speakers. William was chosen twice in the past year to give an address in the town church before a large audience; he does himself credit.

Samuel has been unfortunate. He has lost the use of one leg through what is called scrofulous hip disease and must always use a crutch. He is a good scholar, has taught a school, and was well liked. I hope he will do well.

Besides William and Samuel at college, I have had four girls in school this year. It is expensive. We have had one of the worst droughts I have ever seen. For the first time since I began farming, I must buy *[[missing commodity]]* and pork. Money will be tight at Christmas. I bought Father's land at the sale, and the—

Scan 041 09-041

Farm work, relatives, and life in Rutherford County

—payment is now due. I hope I can meet it. My family is so *[[damaged]]* that living costs a great deal. Every year is harder. This fall I must work harder than ever. Since William went to college, my only help

is *[[Tillis?]]*, a boy of about thirteen, and a girl of about ten. My little girls help pick cotton. I have 180 acres, about 100 cleared. I will rent out about forty acres next year. I also have a *[[damaged description]]* and lot in town, rented for \$100 a year. That and the farm provide all my income. I hope the boys will cost me no more *[[damaged word]]* after this year. They can now *[[damaged wording about supporting themselves]]*. Both are very *[[damaged adjective]]* and attentive to business. Brother Nathaniel is on a farm. His health failed after bleeding from the lungs, but he is doing well now. Sister Cate lives on his farm and manages well. Sister Brandon lives in Kentucky. Brandon practices medicine and was doing well at the last report. That covers our family. I hardly know what else would interest you. Murfreesboro is growing quickly. The old *[[damaged building name]]* is gone, and a fine new one is being built on the same site. If there is anything you would like to know about old Rutherford—

Scan 042 09-042

Ott considers moving to improve his circumstances

—tell me when you receive this letter, and I will write about it.

I would like to see you all again, but fear I never will unless I sell up here and move there. I might do that if it would improve my circumstances. Please write as soon as this arrives. Yours affectionately, A. D. Ott.

To *[[first initial missing]]* L. Douglass.

I also wanted to ask how everyone is doing and which business is most profitable in your area. Please *[[damaged wording requesting a reply]]* as soon as this letter arrives. A. D. Ott.

Scan 043 09-043

Theodosia Nance to Lizzy and Mary, December 16, 1860

Quincy, Tennessee, December 16, 1860. My dear niece,

Your letter arrived on time, but I neglected to answer. Please forgive me. We were glad to hear about the family through you and very sorry to learn through Henry Orr that George's wife had died.

Henry asked why our letters never mentioned Adaline. She has died. Mr. Nance wrote to your father soon afterward. She died of typhus fever on August 29, 1856, in her seventeenth year. She was a kind, affectionate child and a devoted Christian.

White and Robert Jetton have gone to Arkansas and bought land. On the way, they spent a day and night with us. They are intelligent, handsome young men. White resembles his mother and Robert his father. We regret that Henry did not visit when he was in Kentucky; we would have loved to see him and his wife.

Love to the whole family. Tell them to write. My affection and best wishes for your future happiness. Write soon. T. B. Nance, to Lizzy Douglas.

My dear sister,

God has blessed us with health, food, and clothing, for which we are thankful. My health has improved somewhat since my last letter. I am very grateful—

Scan 044 09-044

A train journey to Alabama and relatives moving to Mobile

—to you and Sister Cynthia for inviting me to visit. Sadly, I cannot. I would love to see everyone again and talk face to face.

I traveled about 200 miles by train to Alabama to see Brother Newton. I left Thursday and arrived the next day, October 6. Everyone was well and about to move to Mobile. Newton is healthy and has aged little. Sister Margaret's health is poor, but better than usual this year.

Their family is delightful. Columbia is exceptionally kind, well educated, and capable at all kinds of work. Lula and Mary are very nice girls. Newton has six children—three sons and three daughters. The youngest, Robert Newton, is five. French is a handsome man, well suited to business; Thomas is a lively boy. Martha Fletcher wrote that Newton and his family arrived safely and liked their new home.

Sister Betsey lives with Sister Nancy and says she is happy there. I have invited her to stay with me. Mr. Fletcher has an interest in two steamboats. Newton works as a clerk on one for \$200 a month. Brother Robert is doing well in Mobile and has seven children. Lewis Jetton wrote recently; everyone there was well. Uncle Isaac Waight has died. He died—

Scan 045 09-045

Family news, slavery, and fears for the Union

—on December 4, of dropsy.

Sister Julia's enslaved boy Sam is to be sold on January 6. Lewis thinks the price will be low because of political unrest and scarce money. E. H. Jones has married for the third time, to the widow Hancock.

Sister, when did you last hear from Brother Samuel's widow? Can her relatives support her? Have you met her children? Tell me everything about her. Ask Sister Cynthia to write. I will write to her and Henry soon. Love to all our relatives. Mr. Nance joins me in sending love to you, Mr. Douglas, and the children. Write soon. Your affectionate sister, Theodosia B. Nance, to Mary Douglas.

N. L. Douglass—Dear Sir,

I will add a few lines in the space Theo left. There is little special news. As you know, slavery is causing considerable agitation in our state. No one knows where it will end. I seriously fear that the Union is nearing its end. Our country neighborhood is quiet, but there is great unrest in towns and villages.

This has been one of the healthiest years since we moved to this end of the state. Despite a severe drought, we produced plenty to support ourselves. Prices: corn, 350 cents; wheat, 120 cents; pork, *[[6–7?]]* cents. *[[The original does not state the units.]]*

Scan 046 09-046

Cageville church and letters awaiting forwarding

Old Brothers Cosby and Hall are still alive and reasonably healthy for their age. We worship at Cageville, a village about four miles away, every Sunday. Brother D. Hall lives there. When I moved here, about eighteen members worshiped in his house. We continued there for several months until we could *[[missing verb]]* a meetinghouse, where we still gather.

We have much reason for gratitude and encouragement. The congregation has grown to about 250 members, nearly 100 of whom came from our old county, Rutherford. We therefore have many old acquaintances here in Tennessee. Our relative William Goodloe, a preacher, held a meeting last year that brought about thirty *[[unclear wording]]* additions. He is a very capable man and now lives in Alabama.

You may have seen his name in the American Christian Review.

I still hold two or three letters, apparently from your family, sent to Henry Douglass in my care. I forwarded one to him in Kentucky. He then asked me to send no more until I heard from him. I have waited without further word, so I still have the others. I will forward them to your address soon.

Love to all our friends. I would like to hear more often, so please write. Farewell, W. W. N.

Scan 047 09-047

W. W. Nance on the war and a sick son, April 20, probably 1862

[[County name obscured]], Tennessee, April 20, [[1862?]]. Mr. [[J.?]] D. Orr,

Your welcome letter of March 28 arrived yesterday. We are in our usual health; my wife is rather frail, but health generally is good. We were sorry James was ill and hope he has recovered enough to return home. We know a parent's anxiety over a sick son far away and sympathize deeply.

Your letter expresses my own feelings about what I consider this unholy war. I believe we have not wronged the Yankees, though they have wronged us, and I favor permanent separation. We want them to go home and leave us alone. Otherwise, many will be buried in the South. Despite our setbacks on the rivers, I remain encouraged and believe we can defeat them on land.

Heavy artillery is now heard so often that it draws little notice, though none has been closer than the Mississippi River. The enemy controls the river down to Fort Pillow. I describe that fortification as being at Randolph, opposite Covington, the Tipton County seat. I am told it is strong. Whether we can hold it, I do not know, but their gunboats will have a lively time passing. I hear heavy guns in that direction every few [[obscured words]], but cannot learn the results. [[Unclear words about obtaining news; continues.]]

Reading note. The political views and military information are Nance's contemporary perspective. His geographic descriptions and expectations have not been silently corrected.

Scan 048 09-048

Reports from Shiloh and news of wounded relatives

—[[we are not permitted into the camp; wording damaged]]. On the sixth and seventh, Sunday and Monday, "one week ago," [[damaged words]] there was a great battle at Shiloh, a church near Corinth, Mississippi. Our boys fought [[unclear adjective]] on those days.

William came through both days unscratched, but two men in his company died and several were wounded. A nearby neighbor's boy was killed and another wounded. The wounded one came home; I met him while heading toward Corinth. I was not allowed to proceed and returned.

I am amazed the regiment was not almost wiped out. They reportedly made seven charges and captured a battery each time, yet lost only twenty-five or thirty men.

We live about eighty miles from Corinth or Shiloh. Many wounded men have come here, including my sister's son Shelton, shot through the chest. His wound is not thought dangerous. I had not known he was in the army until the evening before yesterday. At Gadsden station on the Mobile and Ohio Railroad, I learned he was nearby and immediately visited him. Charly enlisted at or near Nashville.

The Yankees hold Union City, at the railroad crossing in Obion County, and Pensacola. You may soon hear of them fleeing Tennessee. Reports say Price and Van Dorn are encamped at Memphis; I have only become convinced of this since beginning my letter.

You say your boys may come to Tennessee. Perhaps they are already at Memphis with Price. If so, I will find them when I am allowed—

Reading note. These are wartime reports and expectations, not an independently checked military history. The writer's own visit to the wounded relative is distinguished from reports about the battle.

Scan 049 09-049

Wartime rumors and Nance's farewell

—to visit the camp. *[[Damaged passage about dislike of Yankees.]]* A rumor has circulated that Nashville has been recaptured, but I do not believe it. I wish it were true, and wish every Yankee would be treated harshly.

I think many men here would become “Tories” if given the chance. I would rather shoot such men than a regular Yankee. None dares reveal himself now, but if the enemy arrives, we must beware.

I have not heard from our friends in Middle Tennessee lately; at last word they were well. I suppose the boys are at Corinth. If I can visit the camp, I will find them.

I must finish. *[[A word describing his feelings about writing is lost.]]* Writing a letter has become difficult, much as I enjoy correspondence. Still, I will answer every letter from you or our friends. Tell them to write, and reply when this reaches you. My wife joins me in sending love to your family and all our relations. Share our news with everyone.

Farewell for now, W. W. Nance.

[[Separate postscript.]] Give my love to Sister Jane and her little Julia. I wish *[[damaged wording]]* she could stay with me. I would be so happy to see you all once more. *[[The address includes Cynthia Orr; the faint closing appears to be T. Nance.]]*

Scan 050 09-050

Theodosia's worry for four sons in the army

[[Opening damaged.]] Sister, since Mr. Nance did not fill the page, I will add a few lines. We have nothing here but trouble and agitation. I know you have your own troubles, with four sons in the army who have left home to defend their homes, country, and liberties. May they return to the family circle to enjoy peace and happiness. *[[Closing words of the wish are unclear.]]*

When we last heard, Sister Rebecca's sons had been ordered to Fort Donaldson. The widow Elery had four sons in the same company; two were killed there. We cannot now get letters from Middle Tennessee. I worry deeply about Sister's boys and do not know whether they fought in the battle.

Cousin William *[[Goddan?]]* and his family went to Rutherford last fall and returned a few weeks ago. If I could see them, I could learn more. After a very wet winter and spring, the water is *[[damaged wording]]* high. Once I can cross the river, I will go to Trenton to see them.

Daniel Hall *[[an unclear reference also mentions old Daniel Hall]]* died at Belmont, leaving a wife and one child. The South considers Shiloh a great victory, but I think it was dearly bought: we lost so many promising young men. Ned Smith, son of Captain Smith formerly of Rutherford, was killed. Colonel Battle and two sons from Rutherford were also reportedly killed. The Yankees are going through Tennessee arresting sick and wounded soldiers.

Tell Lizzy Douglas I will write soon. I would have written earlier, but was told letters could not pass from here to Texas. Love to all our relations; tell them I would like to hear from—*[[end of page]]*.

Reading note. These are the writer's reports and fears. The named deaths and battlefield claims require independent corroboration. The four sons belong to the sister being addressed; that sister is not securely named on this page.

Scan 051 09-051

Envelope to J. D. Orr at Red Oak

Addressed to Mr. J. D. Orr, Red Oak Post Office, Ellis County, Texas. Postage due: 10. Postmark: June 4, with the town and year unreadable. A separate annotation reads “a member of Company *[[B?]]*, 12th Texas Cavalry”; it does not clearly identify which person it describes.

Scan 052 09-052

R. C. Orr describes a repulsed charge, May 17, 1864

Bayou Deglaize, Louisiana, May 17, 1864. Dear Father,
I have an opportunity to write a few lines, though I hardly know how to begin. These are eventful times. As you already know, we have fought almost every day since April 12. Yesterday was the fiercest day we have experienced. The battle began in the morning with heavy cannon fire until about one o'clock. We were then ordered to charge their breastworks. We did, but were driven back with many killed and wounded. John Morgan was—*[[the next page continues “killed”]]*.

Scan 053 09-053

Uncle Alf and Gran Jetton wounded; Henry goes for clothing

—killed. Uncle Alf and Gran Jetton were both wounded in the leg. Their flesh wounds are not considered dangerous. Mr. Calaway of our company was wounded too.

The sergeant reports twelve killed, sixty-five wounded, and two missing. We had about 12,000 men on our side, but no more than half fought. I do not know our total losses, though they were heavy. The Yankees greatly outnumbered us.

Henry has gone to Texas for our clothing; we expect him back any day. Since leaving home I have been in about twenty fights without receiving a scratch, even in tight situations where Minié bullets flew as thickly as hail.

Reading note. The casualty figures and troop strengths are the soldier's reports, with their original limits preserved. The named wounds and relationships should be corroborated before inclusion as settled genealogy.

Scan 054 09-054

Writing on a cartridge box

Jack Lemmons is caring for Uncle Alf and Cousin Gran. They seem to be doing well this evening. Please excuse this short letter. I will do better when I have something better than a cartridge box to write on. Write often and address letters to Shreveport, Louisiana.

Love to Mother, Mary, and all of you, and regards to everyone. As ever, your son, R. C. Orr.

Reading note. The punctuation in the greeting is editorial; the manuscript does not settle whether “Mother” and “Mary” refer to one person or two.

Scan 055 09-055

Bob's camp on the Arkansas River, September 23, 1864

[[Swan?]] Lake, Arkansas, September 23, 1864. Dear Father and Mother,
With an opportunity to send a letter to Texas, I am sitting beside an old rotten bush to write. There is little news. We are camped three miles below the Goodloe place on the Arkansas River, enjoying ourselves

with no battle in prospect. Company D is detached from the regiment. We are camped for forage *[[unclear wording]]* and doing a good deal of hard riding.

I have just returned from Monticello, where I was detailed to guard some cotton smugglers. The command is healthy, with a few cases of chills. My own health is very good.

Old Cider gave out on the journey, so I traded him for a mule—a very good exchange.

I was glad Henry received the assignment to collect clothing, though I wish it had been me. *[[The following reference to Mr. B. M. is unclear.]]*

Please forgive this scribble; I am in a great hurry. Do write. Nothing more for now. Your son, Bob.

Scan 056 09-056

Bob's postscript and address to J. D. Orr

P.S. Lambert Pace asks you to tell his family he is well. Tell Henry to give my regards to everyone.

Address: J. D. Orr, Esquire, Red Oak Post Office, Ellis County, Texas. A possibly crossed-out earlier county name reads *[[Dallas?]]*. Postage due: 10. A faint postal date appears to be *[[October?]]* 8. The service annotation begins "From Company *[[C?]]*, 12..."; the rest is unreadable.

Scan 057 09-057

R. C. Orr at Camp Pisgah, October 15, 1863

Camp Pisgah, Louisiana, October 15, 1863. Dear Father and Mother,

After a long silence, I am writing a few lines, though there is little news. I received your letter to Henry last Monday and was glad everyone at home was well, but sorry about your misfortune. I am healthy now. I had a few chills recently but have recovered. Henry went out with Lieutenant Cox *[[to buy cattle?]]* about two weeks ago. He was well when he left and should return soon.

The command's health is improving, although many still have chills and fever.

Jack *[[Levins?]]*, Jim Lancaster, Gran Alexander, and *[[Pickering?]]* left for Texas on leave this morning. Four men from the company get leave every sixty days; my turn will come eventually.

I would have written yesterday and sent this with Jack, but I did not learn he was leaving until nearly night. We expect old Jeff any day with our clothing. I hope he comes soon: I am tired of camp and want to go out scouting. I must stop until after drill.

Scan 058 09-058

Mock battle, winter clothing, and better food

Drill is over, so I can continue. Yesterday morning we had a general review and inspection. That evening our regiment drilled with Captain Pratt's battery. The men charged the guns, which fired blank cartridges at them—it sounded like a real battle. Colonel Burford bounded about "like a hog in high rye," with *[[Hayberg?]]* following him. There were many spectators, and old Persons tried to make a good impression. Fortunately, I was not taking part.

Our regiment received good clothing recently. Henry was lucky enough to get a fine overcoat, which he badly needed. I received trousers and a shirt. We have had plenty of clothing, and the food here is better than anywhere else during our service. Colonel Burford thinks we will stay here all winter.

Excuse the short letter and poor writing; my pen is bad. Tell Mary to write with all the news, and perhaps I will answer. Nothing more for now. Your obedient son, R. C. Orr.

P.S. Gran Jetton and all your friends are well.

Scan 059 09-059

George urges his sister not to impoverish the family, July 22, 1862

Sabine Pass, July 22, 1862. Sister Lizzy,

Today I can move about *[[unclear words]]*, though I am still very weak. Your letter of the 20th arrived this morning. From the numbering, it seems you forgot to include *[[some pages; the exact wording is unclear]]*.

It is cloudy and rainy. The mosquitoes are so bad that I must stay on the porch. I am writing on my lap *[[unclear description]]*. Father's letter and another letter arrived recently. Warren answered them for me because I could not write then.

If I remember correctly, I only suggested *[[an unclear amount or condition]]* for a substitute. You are all willing to give that much and more, but do not pay so much that you impoverish the property and become entirely dependent on me. I am willing to do everything I can for you. But after we found a substitute, the service requirement might be extended *[[a possible age limit is unclear]]*, and they might take me again, leaving you with nothing. *[[The next phrase about the substitute is unclear.]]*

I know you want me home, and I want to be there. But I do not want you to impoverish yourselves for my benefit. The war might end soon or continue a long time. If it ends soon, paying a high price for a substitute could waste a large sum. My advice is not to obtain one unless you can pay without—

Scan 060 09-060

A substitute's cost, war rumors, and mosquito nets

—a great sacrifice. I do not want you to ruin yourselves for my benefit.

I can endure camp life fairly well; it has not ruined my health yet. I think I will manage well if we remain in a warm climate. Stay cheerful at home and do not worry too much. I am probably doing better than you imagine. *[[An unreadable sum]]* in silver is more than you can spare. I have heard that Platt will give *[[unclear wording about obtaining a substitute]]*. That would leave you too little for yourselves, so I think you should not pay it.

The latest news favors the Southern cause, but you will read it in the papers before this arrives. People say Farragut is trying to mine Vicksburg and blow it up. I can hardly imagine how he would do that; it would be slow work. I do not believe half of what I hear and do not know if this is true. *[[Several following clauses are unreadable.]]*

It has rained several times this past week, and mosquitoes are multiplying rapidly. *[[Part of the next clause is unclear.]]* We will need mosquito nets, or things will be difficult. Major Mann says he has written to Houston four times for them. I do not know whether he has. Somehow nobody wants to believe him, whether he speaks the truth or not.

Scan 061 09-061

George contrasts strict camp rules with guard duty at Galveston

The whole battalion dislikes him because he enforces the regulations so strictly. He ordered every man to have a uniform. The men did not want them but were forced to take them. Now he has ordered everyone to wear a uniform cap, with dress parade every evening. A guard may not sit down: he must keep walking his post and hold his gun the whole time.

That looks reasonable on paper but is very hard in practice. When a guard is relieved, he must accompany the relief party until every guard has been replaced, instead of going straight to the guardhouse.

We never did this at Galveston, even when we expected an attack daily around January 1. After being relieved, we went directly to the guardhouse and slept. On duty we sat, lay down, or walked as we pleased. If our guns became tiring, we leaned them against a house and wrapped ourselves in blankets. Two or three times, while the corporal was replacing the first sentry, the relief party went ahead and replaced everyone else before he could catch up. The senior officers at Galveston knew all this and never complained.

Scan 062 09-062

George's recovery and a postscript, July 23, 1862

[[Much of the upper part of this page remains unreadable. George continues discussing Major Mann's strictness and says he would "do him justice," but the qualifications cannot be recovered securely. Later fragments mention flowers.]]

July 23, 1862. I am considerably better today and hope to be fit for duty in a few days. We are moving uphill. *[[An unclear passage mentions a major, something sent to headquarters, and uncertainty about receiving it.]]* It is impossible to tell; I hope it will be soon. *[[Some wording remains unclear.]]* These are some of the greatest mosquitoes I have ever seen. I am five times as big as I was!

Excuse my poor writing; the mosquitoes *[[unclear wording about biting]]*. Write good, long letters. Affectionately, your brother, George.

Scan 063 09-063

Letter 31: criticism of government cotton dealings, August 8, 1863

Saturday, August 8, 1863. Letter 31. To everyone at home,

It is time to write again, but I have heard nothing from home. *[[Some wording about the transport link through Beaumont is unclear.]]* Almost every day there is a derailment or another problem. *[[The rest of this opening complaint is unclear.]]*

There is no recent news from elsewhere. The *[[Pony Express?]]* reached Beaumont the night before last but brought nothing new. Captain *[[Odlum?]]* returned from several days in Beaumont, aboard the *[[Dime?]]*. He is more downhearted than anyone I have heard. Everything seems to have gone wrong at headquarters, and he has found out about it.

The great Rio Grande speculation scheme has leaked out. I think circumstantial evidence establishes it and the facts can no longer be hidden. Only twenty-five bales of government cotton have reached Brownsville, although only the government's friends have controlled the transport. Mexican "breakers" were employed *[[unclear phrase concerning senior officers]]* to take government cotton to the Rio Grande and remain there. It seems plain who has made a fortune. This has discouraged our captain, as it would anyone with an honest concern for the government.

A man in our battalion named *[[Chisham?]]*, who has been hauling goods to the Rio Grande since we left Galveston, is now with us. He says that when *[[Magruder?]]* was in Brownsville, he sent three staff members to Havana. Yet the man thought he was acting privately. Such men have gone into speculation —*[[the ending is clipped]]*.

Reading note. This preserves George's strong accusations and the reports he repeats. The letter alone does not establish misconduct or the accuracy of the cotton total.

Scan 064 09-064

Guard duty and a proposed return to Galveston

I might as soon return to Galveston as stay here, though we probably would not get quarters as good as before. We would see and hear more and have a livelier time, unless they set us to digging. Some say Cook's artillery will replace us. Defending this place will require both artillery and plenty of pickets. *[[A partly unclear transition complains about running out of ideas.]]* Lately my thoughts do not fill a sheet: it is hard to make something out of nothing. Today is my turn on guard, and somehow I get my share of Sundays on duty. Tonight I must go downriver to watch. We have watched that direction a long time without discovering anything dangerous. We leave after dark and return before the enemy could see us.

Seven prisoners are in the guardhouse for petty offenses. It is an easy place, and some prefer being inside to being outside. I think there should be a lockup for petty officers who lack self-respect and imprison better, innocent men. *[[Part of the original wording is unclear.]]*

Rogers—the man accused of stealing at Dallas, whom we guarded to Houston and handed over to the provost marshal—was tried there and sentenced to three months' work on fortifications. He recently returned to his company. Within about three days he was in the guardhouse again for drunkenness *[[unclear words]]* on guard.

Scan 065 09-065

Letter 32: unpaid troops and reports of mutiny, August 15

Sabine City, August 15 *[[1863 from context]]*. Letter 32. Sister Lizzie, Your July letter arrived Monday evening. Today I received your July 19 letter and Laura's of June 27. They had all rested somewhere along the way.

Lieutenant Baily returned from Houston yesterday with orders for us to move to Galveston once two companies from Elmore's regiment, one from *[[Gould's?]]*, and Captain Jones's artillery relieve us. It will be at least ten days before we leave. We must report to Colonel De Bray. Baily says Sorrell's regiment is mutinous and the troops at Fort Point have turned their guns on the city, demanding better rations.

It is a bad state of affairs if this Confederate government cannot feed men well enough to prevent mutiny. I will learn more when I get there. Here, most of Captain *[[Odum's?]]* company recently refused morning drill. They said they had long been without soap, had no money, and wanted their unpaid wages. Five months' pay is overdue. After a few hours in the guardhouse, they agreed to return to duty. Insubordination and discouragement are widespread. About half our battalion feels beaten and ready to give up. Since Vicksburg fell, the men have looked gloomily ahead. Communication with the east is cut off, and there has been no reliable good news lately—

Scan 066 09-066

Letter 32: damaged discussion of military news

[[Most lines on this page lose their endings at the right edge, so a continuous translation would be misleading.]]

The surviving text discusses the effect of bad news on the men, fighting near Jackson involving Grant and "Johnson," Banks's movements, and the future of the war on either side of the Mississippi. George hopes they will be left alone. He questions extravagant reports about Lee at Williamsport, saying there is little

truth in such big stories. *[[A number beginning “90,” is incomplete.]]*

He also refers to Richmond and Stephens seeking contact with the enemy, calling the timing suspicious. *[[The missing wording prevents a reliable reconstruction of his full argument or the particular proposed contact.]]*

Scan 067 09-067

Letter 32: artillery positions and four kinds of mosquitoes

[[The left side of most lines is missing.]] George reports no serious illness that he knows of, then discusses changes in artillery positions. Two brass howitzers are mentioned, along with a railroad bridge roughly nine or ten miles up the lake. The men assigned there will face mosquitoes without shelter. *[[Gun sizes and parts of the place names are missing.]]*

At last the mosquito nets have arrived, making nights more comfortable. George distinguishes four kinds of mosquitoes: a familiar kind, a smaller striped kind, a charcoal-black fuzzy kind, and the largest kind. He proposes sending a specimen if it survives being crushed in the mail. The largest now seems the most common, swarming in the evenings, at night, and in the mornings. The men must hand over their nets to their replacements when they leave.

[[The final incomplete lines compare this year’s mosquitoes with earlier conditions, then mention a man, sharks, nighttime activity, and calves. Their exact meaning remains unresolved.]]

Scan 068 09-068

Letter 32: summer heat, food, and canceled transfer orders

It is becoming truly hot here. I do not think I ever saw Ellis County this hot. There is scarcely a breeze: just heat, clouds, and still air. Two small lighters and *[[schooners?]]* have brought plenty of good watermelons from Sabine Bayou, sold at fair prices. Our water is good too. Pumpkins are fairly cheap and make a welcome change with bread and beef.

The Zehorlda brought two companies to relieve us last night. But the orders to move to Galveston had already been canceled, so we will remain here indefinitely. I prefer this place until yellow-fever season ends: here we could escape, whereas in Galveston we could not. I have heard nothing of yellow fever in Houston and suspect the report is mistaken. Such stories often circulate at this season.

I hear many men are going home from Louisiana on short leave, generally having “left their certificates of disability behind.” Everyone here is in good health. *[[Jeems?]]* has felt unwell for a few days, but little seems wrong. *[[An unclear or inconsistent phrase follows; George then repeats that everyone is well as far as he knows.]]*

Tell *[[Essie?]]* I will write to her after a while. I was not born a poet and never shall be one. I think that is all the news. Love to everyone. Your brother, George.

Scan 069 09-069

Envelope to Miss Lizzy Douglas, Red Oak

Addressed to Miss Lizzy Douglas, Red Oak, Texas. The sender’s endorsement is partly unreadable; its final military initials may be *[[T. V. B.?]]*. No date can be read securely.

Scan 070 09-070

Letter 21: soldiers take the staff's confiscated liquor, May 14, 1863

Sabine Pass, May 14, 1863. Letter 21. Sister Lizzie,

Yesterday I received your letters of April 29 and 30. They were mailed May 2 and took only eleven days. I do not know why mine fail to reach you; I have written every week.

Since my last letter, the men have had a merry night. I did not join in. The staff are very fond of liquor and leave no stone unturned to obtain it. First they took a demijohn from a boatman, then a barrel of whiskey found in the countryside, then half a barrel of rum from a Frenchman. They reported it destroyed to keep soldiers from getting drunk—but were “destroying” it slowly themselves.

The men finally grew tired of this and decided to finish the whiskey. One night after the tattoo drum signal, the cavalry went to headquarters, rolled out the barrels, and called everyone to come drink for free. They carried the barrels onto the prairie. Everyone brought cups, canteens, coffeepots, and buckets; nearly everyone became drunk.

The staff tried to save the liquor but could not assemble a guard in time. Company C had been organizing its own party to seize it when the cavalry and boat hands arrived. As soon as the commotion began, the long roll sounded. Lanier ordered any man who did not answer his name sent to the—

Scan 071 09-071

Letter 21: the aftermath and daily rations

—guardhouse. Some of the men asked our captain whether they must fall in. He said they could do as they pleased and none of his men would be sent to the guardhouse. I stayed lying down. All the liquor was drunk; only two empty barrels remained. The staff must have been dry since then. Perhaps this will teach them not to take other people's whiskey. The privates had already broken up the showman business here; now they have ended the whiskey business too. Whenever they hear of something bad, they intervene *[[unclear ending]]*.

With all this disorder, I expect we will be sent to Louisiana for active service. The Federals have been quiet lately. Their last action was to order our pickets to halt. Our men kept moving, and the Federals fired without hitting them. The lighthouse guard has ended, leaving little to do but cook and eat. We do the latter perfectly.

We receive a pound and a half of beef and a full allowance of cornmeal daily. Every ten days, we get about three pounds of sugar, a pint of peas, a little over half a pint of vinegar, and some molasses. I must correct the molasses amount: it is one pint for three men for ten days, though generally there is more. We receive less than a quarter of the soap we need, and it is poor. Apart from beef and bread, you might say we get almost nothing. Peas have been issued twice since we left Galveston, and vinegar only occasionally.

Reading note. Written over three unused printed T. H. McMahan & Gilbert payment forms. The forms are stationery, not evidence of three financial transactions.

Scan 072 09-072

April 28 fragment: a captain seeks leave for married men

April 28, year unstated. *[[Opening words unclear.]]* Captain Evans has gone to Houston to obtain leave for the married men. If anyone can succeed, he can: he has a fine manner and a persuasive tongue, and will press his requests on *[[Sammy?]]* with all his ability.

But Camp Long reports that no further leave will be granted. I expect Evans will fail; I see little chance against such a definite order, though I may—*[[the page ends here]]*.

Scan 073 09-073

Fragment continuing the discussion of leave and discontent

Evans will return next Saturday, and then they will know for certain *[[the question about the summer is incomplete]]*. George refers to himself and peace being made, saying he will go with the crowd *[[the connection is missing]]*.

Other surviving phrases concern men tired of corn bread, *[[Dinnie?]]*, an incomplete report about desertion, and less dissatisfaction in the writer's own group. He says no one has left yet. *[[The remaining reference to getting out of a small harbor is incomplete.]]*

Scan 074 09-074

Letter 28: the lighthouse expedition, July 22, 1863

Wednesday evening, July 22, 1863. Letter 28. Sister Lizzie,

My letter is later than usual because I spent three days at the lighthouse. Colonel Griffin set a trap for Yankees there after someone thought he saw one or two. Last Wednesday night, sixty or seventy men under Bickley took possession without resistance. Warren and twenty men remained to capture any Yankees who appeared.

On Saturday night, Lieutenant Deen and twenty men relieved them. I was one of those twenty. Our boat came within about thirty feet of shore, with knee-deep mud between us and land. One man tried to carry a sack of provisions across but became stuck halfway. Warren's party soon brought planks to walk on, and the rest of us reached shore safely. Then the real battle began—with mosquitoes instead of Yankees.

Scan 075 09-075

Letter 28, page 3: conflicting war news

Page 3. Colonel Griffin returned yesterday, having gone only as far as Beaumont. A lieutenant colonel came with him, probably the district inspecting officer. There is no important local news. The militia will be drafted next Saturday.

Reports from the east contradict each other. Some say Vicksburg has fallen, others deny it, though most believe both it and Port Hudson have fallen. Rosecrans has forced Bragg back to the Tennessee River and out of his position at Tullahoma.

One report says Johnson took 8,000 prisoners in a battle with Grant. Why did he not do that before Vicksburg surrendered? Lee is supposedly about to take Pennsylvania and completely defeat Hooker. I suppose it must be true—he has never been beaten! We are to expect him to clear the northeast as Grant clears the southwest. I wish they would stop playing, go home, and let everyone else do the same.

Our chance of leaving here is poor. We might be called to northern Texas this fall to meet the Yankees there. If Vicksburg has fallen, I expect active operations in Louisiana this autumn, unless they work on the other side of the river first.

Scan 076 09-076

Letter 28, page 2: officers under arrest and deaths in the company

Page 2. We fought the mosquitoes bravely until daylight, then drove them out of one room with a “battery of smoke.” After another night waiting and watching *[[the object is written “neds,” meaning uncertain]]*, we returned without catching anything. No one is stationed there now.

Back at camp, I found our captain under arrest for refusing to salute Major Hammer at dress parade and cursing him. Hammer himself is under arrest for drawing a revolver on Captain Payne. Griffin has gone to Houston, and Hammer with him. I hear Hammer wants to resign and go home; he should have every opportunity once this affair is settled. Captain Odlum now commands the post, and Captain *[[Mc R?]]* commands the battalion.

Thursday, July 23. The boat arrived late yesterday but brought no letter for me. My latest letters from home are Laura’s of June 24 and 25. I cannot explain the delay: letters from Tarrant County dated July 6 have arrived.

Two more men in our company have died, both at Beaumont: Mark Evans on Monday evening and William K. *[[Joyn?]]* last Friday. William had measles. The sick men here are doing well.

Scan 077 09-077

Letter 28: inspection, fort construction, and fading hopes of peace

The steamer leaves this evening, so I must close. Lieutenant Colonel McNeil inspected us grandly this morning: review, marching past him, weapons inspection, battalion drill, company drill, then the manual of arms. We were on the parade ground from 8:30 until 11. We were glad to see him leave. Men here certainly enjoy displaying authority.

Captain Evans has been released from arrest; from what I hear, Major Hammer has too. Griffin has assured Hammer his resignation will be accepted. A doctor’s certificate of disability should ensure it. We will be glad to lose him on any terms and hope for a better replacement.

Work on the fort is slow. More Black workers have been requested. No one can say when it will be finished. The estimated cost to the government is \$100,000. Please tell me who has been drafted in our county; I want to know how many men remain.

People here have abandoned hope of an early end to the war. Almost everyone believes Vicksburg has fallen, and the cherished idea of foreign intervention has died.

It is still rainy, though the past few days have been fairly pleasant. My paper is nearly full. Goodbye for now, George.

Scan 078 09-078

May 17, 1863: a musical evening for the battalion

May 17, 1863. The Grand Bay arrived Friday night without any letters for me. Warren did not come. I suppose he has decided to stay away; we have not heard from him since April 12. He wrote that he would either report for duty by May 1 or seek a discharge *[[the wording before “for a discharge” is crossed out]]*. A boat is due from Beaumont today; perhaps it will bring news.

Last night Parson Simmons and Dr. Barton organized an evening of music and living pictures. Admission was one dollar, for the benefit of Griffin’s battalion. I treated myself to a ticket. It was better than I expected—the first entertainment of this kind that I have—

Scan 079 09-079

Thirty-five scenes and a three-hundred-dollar benefit

—attended. They presented about thirty-five different scenes and finished so late that I think they encroached a little on Sunday. Local women took an active part, playing several comic characters. The event raised about three hundred dollars with almost no expense to its organizers. Parson Simmons opened with prayer, though everyone soon forgot his pious sentiments. I am fairly confident the money will benefit the soldiers. If it does not, I am ready to expose the whole affair. Things are dull and there is no other news. Goodbye, G.

Scan 080 09-080

Letter 23: food and soap at Sabine Pass, May 28, 1863

Sabine Pass, May 28, 1863. Letter 23.

As I mentioned, your letter of the 7th arrived the other day. I will answer it more fully now. I was sorry Sam was sick; illness is so unpleasant. I have been rather unwell myself, but am nearly recovered. Living on Sabine beef and bread is miserable compared with what I have known. We get a few other things, but must buy any vegetables. This spring has been so dry that local people have grown little more than they need. They mostly keep gardens, with no farms, and live on vegetables, beef, and whatever they buy. Most own many cattle, but this year have produced little milk or butter to sell. Some will only give us things, never sell them, so the men keep going to those people. Those who do sell are soon bought out. It is almost impossible to get clothes washed. The government does not supply enough soap even for socks, and the townspeople are generally out. Men have searched three or four miles around for washing, but everywhere the answer is “no soap!”

Thank you for the socks, though I would have preferred woolen ones. Warren also brought the pills and fine comb. Happily, I have not needed the comb since leaving home and hope I will not *[[the rest of the line is cut off]]*.

Reading note. A probable further continuation is at 09-099–100.

Scan 081 09-081

Letter 23: delayed mail and cancelled furloughs, May 28–31, 1863

Letters seem to take half as long again between here and home as they did from Galveston. I seldom receive one in fewer than twenty days, though one arrived eleven days after posting. The Sunflower is due this evening; perhaps a letter or two will come too.

Captain Evans and Corporal Long started home after Sammy restored the old furlough arrangements. One day after they left, the order was cancelled again. I do not know whether they can continue home without angering Sammy. The order lasted only thirty-six hours; something bad must have happened to cause such a sudden reversal.

Newspapers dated the 20th said a major battle was expected at Grand Gulf, forty or fifty miles below Vicksburg. Perhaps we have been defeated there. But you have as much access to newspapers as I do. Tell me when your Telegraph subscription ends, and I will try to send news for a while. Its rates have doubled, so yours must be nearly finished.

We had a pleasant shower this evening, the first in about a month, but far too little. Water is growing scarce in the cisterns.

Sunday, May 31. No boat has arrived yet, though the Sunflower is confidently expected today. She has

been carrying troops to Niblett's Bluff for several days. I have no idea how many are crossing; there must lately have been some danger in that direction.

Reading note. A probable further continuation is at 09-099–100.

Scan 082 09-082

Envelope addressed to Lizzie Douglas at Red Oak

To Miss Lizzie Douglas, Red Oak, Texas. No sender or date is clearly readable.

Scan 083 09-083

Galveston under shellfire: letter dated January 22, uncertain year

Galveston, January *[[22?]]*, *[[1862?; year uncertain]]*. Dear Sister,

Life here is monotonous. Galveston is much prettier than Houston, with less mud, better drainage, and easier access to shells for paving. I think it is much healthier too.

Yesterday the Federals interrupted the monotony by shelling the town and Fort Point, about two miles east of us. They began around three o'clock and fired 107 shots. The damage I know of was four men wounded at Fort Point, one of whom has since died.

Many residents had returned home; they now fled west with their families. Black workers at the east end hurried west too. Some soldiers threw a barrel head among them and shouted, "There's a bomb!" The frightened people fell face down on the hard pavement.

I spent most of the bombardment in a lookout above our quarters, where I could see the smoke from every shot and hear the guns.

Most of the firing came from the gunboat Sciota. I do not know whether she is ironclad. She came within about a mile of the south battery and fired at the town and surrounding ground, presumably to discover any batteries. The Brooklyn fired at Fort Point throughout—

Scan 084 09-084

Galveston letter: shells, a flag of truce, and captured ships

—and after the first few rounds, almost every shell hit its target. The Brooklyn fired about four miles, dropping shells among the tents or batteries every time. The firing was close enough to cut a *[[flagstaff at the railroad pier?; wording uncertain]]*.

One shell from the Sciota came singing straight toward my lookout. It seemed so directly aimed at me that I involuntarily ducked. It was the only shell that came near me.

This morning I saw three unexploded shells. Two were round and would weigh about 130 pounds. The third, from a rifled gun, was elongated, steel-pointed, and about five inches across by fifteen inches long. Five vessels are now in sight. I doubt they will attack before reinforcements arrive. A flag-of-truce mission went out two days ago on undisclosed official business and learned that the Federals intend to attack soon. I cannot tell how much is truth and how much bluster. They say they can defeat us here and intend to do it, but their actual intentions are uncertain.

The rigging from the two captured barques has been removed and stored. The blockade prevents their leaving, and shallow water prevents moving them to Houston, so they must stay here.

The Harriet Lane has been repaired and, I hear, is ready for sea, but she cannot get out either. Steamboats run between here and Houston, though there is little travel.

Scan 085 09-085

Severely faded letter: military and religious discussion

This page is too faded for a dependable continuous reading. Legible fragments mention very cold, wet and gloomy weather, New Year's Day, public spirit, scattered forces, someone called "Granny," a "female General," newspapers, Bibles, prayers and cannon. The place, date and the argument connecting these fragments remain unreadable. The following page preserves a much clearer discussion of prayer and warfare.

Reading note. This is an account of the surviving readable fragments, not a complete modernization. Gaps in the reference transcription identify the unreadable passages.

Scan 086 09-086

George questions prayers for victory in war

[[The opening discussion of religion is too faint for a continuous reading.]]

I cannot see how anyone can, in good conscience, pray for an army's success in a battle where wholesale murder reigns. Both sides kneel to the same God and pray for opposite results. Obviously, both cannot be blessed or favored; one or both must be wrong. The prayers of the wicked cannot be answered. The sin of making a wicked prayer seems to me reason enough to restrain people from praying for success outside the Church—or at least for success in war.

Life is quiet here, with no prospect of moving. Our mess recently exchanged its tent for a house, so we are getting along fairly well.

Yesterday we went opposite the lighthouse and fired cannon shots *[[number unclear]]* to let the Yankees know that the *[[Clifton?]]* is still around. The vessel's name and part of the following remark are uncertain. Her guns have been put aboard, and there is an intention to send her to sea with cotton before long. Two "32s" were put aboard for the purpose just mentioned.

Early in March, the roads were hard enough to bear a man's weight. *[[The remaining weather remark and part of the statement that no letter has come from home are faint.]]*

Goodbye, George.

Reading note. Uncertain opening and closing passages have not been filled from historical context. The discussion of conscience and prayer is retained in full.

Scan 087 09-087

Susanna to Joda: the baby and mosquitoes, June 29

June 29, year not given. Dear Joda,

Lizzie has written George a long letter with all the news, so there is no point repeating it. I have nothing more of interest to add. George will let you and Warren read his letter.

The children and I are well. Mosquitoes are tormenting the baby, biting her face, hands, legs and feet and leaving great hard lumps. This makes her very fretful. I hope it will not—

Reading note. A later identifying note attributes the letter to Susanna Douglas Bell and expands Joda's initials as J. M.

Scan 088 09-088

Susanna's letter: mosquitoes and news of a refugee

—rain again for a long time, so that dry weather may kill the troublesome mosquitoes. Our place could compare with Sabine, or anywhere else, for mosquitoes now.

I saw old John D. Thomas at church last Sunday but did not speak to him. I understand the Federals drove him out of Arkansas, and he is here as a refugee. His wife has been dead nearly two years. I do not know where his children are.

Your letter of June 8 reached me a few days ago.

[[An upside-down marginal note mentions “my ring”; the rest cannot be read reliably.]]

Scan 089 09-089

September 22, 1864: surveying office, military service, and taxation

Sabine Pass, September 22, 1864. Dear Brother,

Your bundle of letters has arrived, including our sister's and your note of August 20 *[[place unclear]]*.

I appreciate your concern and your acceptance of the surveyor's office with my interests in mind. But I doubt the plan can help me, under my understanding of the law. Being a surveyor can keep a man out of military service, but cannot release one already serving. Chief justices, sheriffs and county clerks can be released because Confederate law requires those offices; surveyors do not have the same standing.

I sympathize with your financial troubles and fully share your hatred of oppression, tyranny and misuse of public funds. I do not go quite as far in opposing the taxes, excessive and poorly based though they are.

Such a war inevitably burdens us heavily; a new government cannot be blamed simply for high taxation. I am sorry sufficient money taxes were not raised to pay for government and war *[[the wording about depreciation and its continuation is awkward]]*.

Scan 090 09-090

War news, the presidential election, and a surveying compass

Still, we could have managed our actual needs and blundering legislation fairly well if dishonest dealing had not multiplied our troubles fourfold.

There has been little news since Atlanta fell. Fighting near Jonesboro, twenty miles south of Atlanta, is said to have gone against the Yankees. Our acknowledged losses around Atlanta through September 7 are *[[17,500?; figure uncertain]]*, including the prisoners lost at Jonesboro. The Yankees reportedly admitted more than 1,200 losses since their advance, excluding the latest fighting. They still hold the Weldon Railroad south of Petersburg; both sides expect a major battle nearby.

If the newspapers are reliable, McClellan's election is almost certain. Some think that will bring peace, either by restoring the Union with guarantees of Southern and state rights, or by recognition. Others disagree. I have nearly concluded that the future is “a millstone without the hole in the middle to look through.” I can only hope for the best.

Regarding your questions, I have already written to E. D. that you may use my compass and whatever instruments you can find. *[[The wording introducing the indispensable instruments is awkward.]]* The scale and—

Scan 091 09-091

Practical surveying: triangles, traverse tables, and closing a boundary

—dividers, and sometimes the protractor, which I think I left at home. A traverse table is indispensable for irregularly shaped surveys. *[[The next sentence's wording is awkward.]]* Latitude and departure form the base and perpendicular of a triangle whose measured distance is the hypotenuse. With the direction known, a measured side and the table give the other two sides. Irregular surveys must be divided into triangles to calculate their area. Multiply the base by the perpendicular and divide by two.

When a survey rests against another, treat the older lines as the base. The divergence from their direction is the departure, and the last lines are the latitude, regardless of the compass points. Field notes must balance. The traverse table is the easiest way to correct or determine unknown lengths in irregular surveys.

In practice, measurements may fail to close by a chain or two on *[[uneven?]]* ground. Leave the most favorable side to be measured last. For the same reason, *[[the wording is imperfect, but appears to advise delaying the final placement of the beginning corner]]* until you have gone all the way around. Then place it where—

Scan 092 09-092

Surveying advice: boundaries, field notes, and compass variation

—the closing line meets the beginning line. A few varas more or less is a small and common measuring error, but a line departing from its proper bearing is a different problem. *[[A short insertion says errors must balance, followed by unclear figures.]]*

Surveys should be as nearly square as possible, and should not leave gaps of less than eighty acres between them. *[[Part of the instruction concerning existing boundaries is unclear.]]* When placing a new survey against an old one, the writer discusses marking corners or line trees and keeping the field notes consistent with the direction first followed.

His example starts on a line bearing north 60 degrees east, then proceeds around the other sides back to the boundary and closes along it. To make the tract as nearly square as possible, the average of the north and south lines should equal the east or west line.

In practice, first adjust the compass needle's variation to agree with older lines. Ten degrees is most common here, but it varies from nine to twelve degrees and sometimes more. It is now customary to state the variation used at the bottom of the field notes.

Scan 093 09-093

George to Laura: making things to pass the time, July 17, 1864

Manhasset, July 17, 1864. Sister Laura,

Once again I am trying to write with nothing amusing or interesting to say. Life is dull and quiet. *[[A phrase about peace is incomplete.]]* For the first time in a long while, our company has had preaching.

The preacher *[[name damaged]]* is a Baptist, though I do not remember which branch. Today's mail brought your July letter with a brief account of the meeting in progress *[[details damaged]]*.

[[Several damaged lines discuss ornaments.]] I have some idea how fond people are of adornment, from a *[[shell?]]* ring to a breastpin—anything to attract attention and make a display. Every kind of taste is enlisted for that purpose, whether it succeeds or not.

Men confined to one place will do almost anything to pass the time. Following that general human

tendency, Company D had gathered tools and begun making combs, shoes and other useful articles. The inspecting officer reported to headquarters that they were making more money than *[[the comparison is damaged]]*. Headquarters ordered their tools taken away and prohibited manufacturing, whether for sale or otherwise. Their time is now doubly monotonous.

Manufacturing still proceeds at a moderate pace here. The “head fiddler” is away on furlough, so trade is not thriving. Many hours are idle, though nearly a quarter of our company now sit in chairs of their own.

Scan 094 09-094

George to Laura: hopes of peace and an unwelcome hat

I received a letter from Jim the other day and enclose it, hoping you would rather read it than *[[the damaged phrase appears to compare it with one of mine]]*. The boys across the river must be bored and dislike being hemmed in by *[[“Granny”?; part missing]]*. Heavy fighting continues there. Reports say the Yankees are beaten everywhere and predict an early peace. Peace is very desirable, but *[[part of the next remark is lost]]*. There seems to be a more brotherly feeling between the armies *[[supporting details are damaged]]*. Will it last?

I wonder how “Rebel Sam” feels as old age approaches with little prospect of a “Union” between “Opposite parties”! *[[Part of the teasing comparison with “Auld Lang Syne” is lost.]]*

I forgot to describe my hat: a large, ugly, heavy felt thing, described as white and drab, with an unbound brim and no finishing touches. *[[Details about its price are damaged.]]* The carrier got it from Uncle Jesse Evans, who simply told him to bring it down. I prefer my Yankee cap.

We recently received clothing, including a shirt, a pair of pants and shoes. *[[Part of the list and a joking remark about another man are damaged.]]*

It is nearly supper time, and I have run out of news and the other things people use to fill a letter. Jody has given the news, if there is any; I know I have not.

Yours for the war, George.

Scan 095 09-095

Battle account: a fragment left alone in the bay

[[The beginning and edges are missing.]] I did not know then how many were *[[the phrase ends “for eternity”]]*. Looking back, I saw our small fragment of a company alone in the bay; the rest had halted *[[location partly missing]]*. Farther back, the Federals again swept our line with fire, and I again heard the wounded crying “O! O!” beside me. *[[The last damaged line mentions the bulk of the company reaching a hill.]]*

Reading note. A later note identifies George Douglas as the writer. The battle cannot be securely named from this fragment alone.

Scan 096 09-096

Battle account: bullets striking the water

[[Only a fragment survives.]] I heard several muffled cries beside me and knew some men had been hit. *[[Part of the next phrase is missing.]]* Bullets struck the water thickly all around me, but most thickly on my left, where our men were. I saw most of the men fall, but all except one got up again.

Scan 097 09-097

George to Lizzie: rain, coastal war news, and a change of command, August 20, 1864

Sabine Pass, August 20, 1864. Sister Lizzie,

Your letter of the 5th is before me. I scarcely remember whether I have answered it. Life has been dull for the past week because heavy rain has made getting around town difficult. There is plenty of deep mud, but the sun is drying it. A few rainless days should make things pleasant again. The rain lasted three days. *[[Some coastal news is damaged.]]* Fort Gaines has surrendered, and a Yankee fleet is in the bay. Fort Morgan still holds out, though it may be taken. The last two newspapers offered no further news, and people are anxious about both Mobile and Atlanta.

A private report says Johnson was called from Georgia to command an expedition to *[[Maryland?]]*, over Breckinridge, Early and others. I would not rely much on this report, though it might be true.

Magruder has left for Arkansas, to the troops' general delight. No man has been given up with less regret. General Hébert is temporarily in command until Walker arrives. We hope Walker will do better, especially about furloughs. *[[The final damaged lines continue discussing Magruder's lack of popularity.]]*

Scan 098 09-098

Peach cobbler and the difficulty of writing a long letter

I went into the country this morning and bought a bucket of peaches for five dollars. I expect peach cobbler for supper. Would you like to join me? The peach crop has been heavy, considering how few orchards there are. *[[Part of the discussion of orchards is damaged.]]* This climate suits peaches, oranges, figs, pomegranates, lemons, quinces, bananas and other tropical produce. Orange trees are loaded; if we remain until winter, we may eat more of their fine fruit.

[[A damaged passage discusses the paper he is using and reassures Lizzie that she may write freely without concern about its cost.]]

You wanted a long letter, but I must disappoint you: nothing exciting is happening in camp or elsewhere that I know of. Little short of a fight could stir me to a long letter, and I have grown used to receiving short ones from home. If a fight or something unusually interesting happens, I will tell you in as few words as possible.

[[Part of his explanation is damaged.]] I cannot keep up the excitement needed to write four or six pages every time. If we traveled, perhaps something worth writing about would turn up.

[[The letter ends with teasing about an unnamed person, followed by a comic list including red hair, freckles, crooked teeth, a wide mouth, long nose, stooped shoulders, thin legs, knock knees, club feet and a "raw boned specimen of humanity." Some linking words are lost.]]

Scan 099 09-099

May 31: a flag of truce and a Northern newspaper

May 31, probably 1863. The boat is in sight, ten or fifteen miles away, so I will try to finish before it arrives. Boats are welcome as our link with the outside world.

A flag-of-truce boat recently went out to the blockading ships to learn what had happened to a man named Taylor. Ill treatment by secessionists had driven him to the Yankees, and he was wounded in the lighthouse fight. His wife, who lives about twenty-five miles upriver, requested the inquiry. If his fate was learned, it has not been announced.

The boat brought recent Northern newspapers. I read the New York Times yesterday. It firmly supports the Union as it was and the Constitution as it is, offers the rebels no peace, and calls on patriotic men to keep fighting until the rebellion is suppressed. If two more years will not finish it, the next administration may pursue it with renewed vigor.

Its account of the recent Hooker–Lee battle gives a Union loss figure that is now damaged, and Confederate losses of roughly 20,000–25,000 *[[part of the range is damaged]]*. It claims 2,500 prisoners and seventeen artillery pieces. It says a sudden rise in the Rappahannock cut rail communication with the rear for twelve *[[unit lost]]*, and that Confederate troops did not interfere with the retreat. It also prints Commodore Porter’s report on the capture of Grand Gulf *[[date damaged]]*.

Scan 100 09-100

George’s response to Laura: “I write every thing about myself”

Porter says he has the gateway to Vicksburg. In his dispatch, he says the natural defenses at Grand Gulf are stronger than Vicksburg’s and that completed fortifications would have made the place impossible for him to take. The newspaper says nearly half the prisoners will take the oath of allegiance.

It also describes General Stoneman’s cavalry raid behind Lee’s army, claiming destruction of rail connections to Richmond and bridges over the Chickahominy, an approach within two miles of Richmond, and the capture of an aide on General Winder’s staff. It describes Northern troops as confident of eventual success. Reports also say Stonewall Jackson has died of his wound and General Van Dorn has been killed in a private quarrel.

The boat brought Laura’s letter of the 15th–16th. She says I am reserved about myself. I do not think so: I tell you everything about myself, or everything I do. I assumed you already knew the temptations of camp life. *[[A short phrase about writing is unclear.]]*

Having nothing to do is the worst drawback, apart from military routine itself. *[[A few words before the reference to grumbling and discontent are missing.]]* If something does not suit me, it is not my fault; I do not manage things, so getting angry does no good. When I dislike something, I think contemptuous thoughts privately without troubling anyone else.

Because I have no control, I have little to fret over. My only responsibility is the ordinary routine of soldiering, and playing my part is not difficult now that I am used to it.

Affectionately, George.

Scan 101 09-101

George in Houston: uncertainty about orders, March 19, 1865

Houston, March 19, 1865. Sister Lizzie,

I am writing again from here with little idea how long we may remain. We have no reliable information about our next movements, though most think we will go east of the Mississippi this spring. Few want to go, I assure you, but few would refuse if ordered.

There is little important news. A rumor a few days ago said Sherman had been defeated in battle and Beauregard killed. The newspapers say nothing about it. The last reliable reports said Sherman and Hardee were racing for Charlotte, with Sherman likely to arrive first.

There will clearly be active campaigning there this spring. Unless Yankees come this way, someone from this department will surely have to go east of the Mississippi. Either an attack on Galveston is feared, or coastal troops will be relieved and sent into the field. The old troops from Louisiana and Arkansas are all coming this way.

Scan 102 09-102

Troop movements, coffee, and a sermon without politics

Henry Orr wrote on the 13th that they expected to move to the Brazos country in a few days: forage around Waverly was exhausted. He asked me to reply to Hempstead, where DeBray's regiment already is. Tom wrote from Tyler on the 10th that his old regiment was marching to Hempstead. I understand Walker's old division and Green's old brigade have orders too. To me, this suggests fear of an attack on the coast, or starvation in Louisiana and Arkansas.

We are healthy and live fairly well. We pooled our money and bought a sack of flour and thirty pounds of coffee, so our household has coffee and biscuits. That brings our coffee purchases since arriving here to about forty-five pounds.

Confederate money has fallen to "27" again *[[the basis is not stated]]* and circulates poorly. Coin is scarcer too. Goods are generally cheaper because money is scarce. Blockade running continues at Galveston and keeps the market supplied. Cotton carding tools sold at auction for 1.60 a pair when bought by the dozen pairs.

Today I heard the old Presbyterian preacher give an excellent sermon without mentioning the war, the Confederacy, Jeff, Abe or any other political dignitary.

As ever, your brother, George.

Scan 103 09-103

Envelope addressed to Lizzie Douglas

To Miss Lizzie Douglas, Red Oak, *[[Ellis County?]]*, Texas. A faint postal annotation includes "25"; the rest is uncertain.

Scan 104 09-104

A March letter to Lizzie: spelling and an island spring

March *[[22?]]*, year not stated. Sister Lizzie,

I am answering your letter of the 4th, number 7, enclosed in Jody's. It arrived two days ago.

Your letter writing is improving. A few more severe criticisms might help, but I do not mean to be hard on you—only to correct an occasional word. *[[He gives two spelling examples, both uncertain in the scan.]]*

Today is very pleasant. Now that winter has broken and spring has come, the sea breeze blows constantly. Without the warmer air, I could scarcely tell it was spring: roses bloomed all winter, the evergreens never change, and the gardens look as well as they have throughout winter. There are no woods on the island—

Scan 105 09-105

Tired of the treeless island; fleas, flies, and fortifications

—and therefore no birds to announce spring. I am tired of looking at empty stretches of water and land without woods or hills.

We will probably find plenty of timber in eastern Texas. The fleas are so troublesome that I would gladly get away from them on any honorable terms. Our nearest neighbor, Mr. Schmitt, says the flies will be gone in a month. I would gladly see them go now.

There is no local news. Obstacles are being placed in the channels to keep outsiders out, and fortifications

are being built. The city should soon be defensible.
Most people say peace is near, but I—

Scan 106 09-106

Doubts about peace and news from Poland

—still cannot see a bright prospect. Prominent leaders think the war will be long. Colonel Ashbel Smith's letter says to prepare for a thirty-year war. The Northwest is deeply dissatisfied but says nothing about peace.

The new conservative party there promises no mercy. The writer believes the Republican Party is declining and a powerful conservative movement is replacing it; Republicans will try to retain power but will lose it. *[[An awkward sentence then criticizes leaders for holding power despite the people.]]*

A major revolution seems to be underway in Poland. The Poles have lost a battle, but are undiscouraged and gain strength daily. Prussia has allowed—

Scan 107 09-107

George on choosing when—and whom—to marry

—Russia to move troops across its territory. That amounts to joining forces against Poland to crush what he calls Europe's last hope of liberty.

The girls in Ellis seem to be getting desperate, saying they will marry when the war is over—and boldly announcing it! I plan to do my own marrying when the war ends. I do not expect to decide whom to join with until then. As the boys say, I generally do as I please in matters such as marriage and letter writing. You received no letter when Sue got Jody's of the 28th because I did not write until the next day. Then I wrote a very long one.

Your brother, G. D.

Scan 108 09-108

George mourns his sister, March 10, 1865

Houston, Texas, March 10, 1865. To everyone at home,

I was deeply saddened to hear of my sister's death from Captain Evans, who arrived a few days ago. I never expected such sad news. It came unexpectedly, but was all too true. We can only weep for those who have died, though our sorrow cannot bring them back. The evidence they left of their hope of immortality comforts those left behind.

It gives me greater happiness to know that she died hoping for heaven and everlasting joy than if she had been crowned the richest queen on earth. We mourn her loss, but *[[a damaged passage refers to her gain]]*. It seems hard that she should be taken from her young family. Yet Providence's ways are best, and we must submit without complaint.

It is terribly sad for the children to lose their protector so early, and the care and love only a mother can give, leaving them almost on their own in the world for a time. Sympathy for them deepens our sorrow. We must do everything we can for them, separated by fate or fortune from their only parent.

More than ever I feel needed at home, but my chances of returning soon seem smaller and smaller. As we go on, the future grows darker, with *[[not one?]]* ray of light ahead.

Scan 109 09-109

"Any way almost would suit me now": George longs for the war to end

There are many rumors that we will be ordered across the Mississippi, or to Louisiana. I am fairly sure we will start east somewhere by the beginning of next month. If sent across the river, an individual would have little chance of remaining here, because transfers would not be allowed. Almost all the men oppose such a move, but you know what orders mean. It is reported that Lee has ordered 30,000 troops east of the Mississippi. If true, I fear the worst. I will try not to worry more than I can help; I only wish my service were over.

Our only news comes through the blockade. Sherman is occupying coastal cities almost *[[without?]]* opposition, while *[[Lee?]]* is concentrating his forces. I expect this year's campaigning to take place mostly in the field. Perhaps it will bring the war to an end, through subjugation if nothing else. Almost any ending would suit me now.

Today has been a day of fasting, and everything has been quiet. I do not attend their war meetings or sermons.

The country is ready to accept any kind of government now and submit to anything: its spirit is broken. It is late and cold, so I will close.

With love to all, affectionately, George Douglas.

Scan 110 09-110

Envelope addressed to Laura Douglas at Red Oak

To Miss Laura Douglas, Red Oak, Texas. The postmark is incomplete and its date unreadable.

Scan 111 09-111

George to Laura: dry weather and the stranded Clifton, March 11, 1864

Sabine Pass, March 11, 1864. Letter 60. Sister Laura,

This week's mail brought your letter of February 21. It found us all doing well. You have had cold weather too; from what I hear, the winter has been fairly severe everywhere.

It remains very dry. Without rain soon, our cistern water will run out, and the well water is poor. Life around Sabine Pass goes on as usual, with little to attract attention. The pleasant weather only increases the common garrison disease of laziness.

Two men in our company are ill, one at Beaumont and one here. Both have pneumonia, one following measles, the other an ordinary case. From what I can learn, neither is in much danger.

The Clifton has not left yet. She tried about two weeks ago but ran aground on an oyster reef at high tide. She lay tilted for a day and a night, opening a leak in her bottom. It is not bad enough to keep her in port, and she will try again when conditions are favorable.

Scan 112 09-112

George questions newspaper victories and growing rumors

Our news from outside is scanty: only what the newspapers supply. Naturally, they give us the favorable version, even when it is unreliable. Lying has become so fashionable that nearly every source of information is full of it. Some people seem so practiced and accustomed to it that they can lie without knowing it.

Sherman has supposedly been badly beaten in Mississippi twice! The first time, he certainly ran fast—but

unfortunately for the South, the Rebels were ahead of him. If his latest retreat was like the first, where is Polk now?

The farther a story travels, the bigger it becomes. Since Vicksburg fell, news must come by a roundabout route and grows accordingly. We cannot trust details from east of the Mississippi, only the broad outline—and that looks rather dark.

Your letters suggest some strange ideas have reached the upper country. Yankees and Rebels must be on better terms farther west if schooners can pass in and out freely with only a few blank shots fired at them. Here they shoot to hurt. When nothing more entertaining offers itself, the Yankees shell our sentries on the beach.

Scan 113 09-113

War weariness and teasing Laura about marriage

Several Yankees came ashore around dark the other evening. Our cavalry failed to capture them because they could not find them in the night. The people in your area seem thoroughly beaten down, even more than the soldiers—or perhaps they speak more freely. Maybe we are brave and maybe not; who knows? There is less talk about military affairs now. Everyone seems indifferent. Boasting about Confederates and belittling Yankees is an old, worn-out song, scarcely hummed anymore. No one explains how women and children will live when their present supplies are gone, or seems greatly interested. Still, this quiet may last only a few weeks before everything becomes turmoil again.

And people still marry! I was surprised by Mary *[[Patton's?]]* marriage, thinking her too young to leave her mother. I know Em Chapman only by reputation, and barely that. I believe she is Lizzie's cousin; I wonder whether Lizzie will do the same. White people are unpredictable, and so are women.

Do not marry some gentleman of the "Bush" merely because the opportunity comes. Better call back "*[[Bowle?]]*" first, though he is old and rather redheaded.

Scan 114 09-114

Jayhawkers, writing paper, and beef buried with military honors

A raid by Jayhawkers from the Louisiana swamps toward Niblett's has attracted some notice. I understand Green's brigade has been sent to deal with them. There is quite a group beyond Calcasieu Lake, causing trouble in that area. They are reportedly supported by Banks—but nowadays every kind of wrongdoing is blamed on Yankees.

I have enough paper for six months, so do not worry about supplying me. I am grateful to Sister for her present but will not need it for a while. Perhaps the changing fortunes of war will let me visit home and collect it when I need it. Tell her I will try to write this month. I received Mary's letter recently. I must tell her she is still very modest and should outgrow that.

Gilbert, one of our company, has been released from the guardhouse. He is the man who left *[[Millican?]]* sick and went home last fall.

We still have enough to eat, but it is poor food. Some troops on Galveston Island have gone without beef for a week. The last they received was so bad that they buried it with military honors and refused any more because it was no better.

Affectionately, George.

Scan 115 09-115

George travels down the Brazos, April 11, 1865

Houston, April 11, 1865. Sister Laura,

I promised a longer letter this week, so I must keep my promise. On Wednesday morning I started for Velasco. It was dry but cloudy. I reached Columbia on the Brazos River at four that afternoon.

Columbia is a small place, notable chiefly as the railway terminus *[[the initials are uncertain]]*. The railway crosses low, flat, fertile country, mostly prairie and sparsely settled, though a few wealthy planters live along it. The Brazos is the prettiest river I have seen in this part of the country. It is about a hundred yards wide and very deep, with cottonwoods, willows, and quicksand along its banks.

On Thursday morning I left Columbia aboard the steamboat Era No. 3 for Velasco, about fifty miles downriver. The sky remained cloudy, with wind from the east *[[part of the description is lost]]*. Eight miles below Columbia lies Brazoria, a small town in the riverside woods and the only town below Columbia. The boat stopped along the way to collect men of Bates's regiment who had been hunting in the river bottoms and cutting poles for cookhouses at the river's mouth. *[[A further line is clipped.]]*

Scan 116 09-116

Delivering a prisoner and finding Dock at Velasco

Four or five miles above Velasco, the woods end and the river emerges onto open prairie. Like Sabine, the land is low and flat, with riverbanks scarcely eighteen inches high. Near the edge of the woods stood some of what I call Magruder's "ground hogger": a small field fort with two openings for guns. Another earthwork, holding one gun, stands about two miles above the mouth.

We arrived at Velasco around three o'clock, with a strong, cold east wind. I found headquarters *[[the following abbreviation is uncertain]]* and delivered my prisoner as ordered. Then I looked for Dock. I soon found him but would not have recognized him. His beard has not seen a razor for years, and he is about as gray as Father. He was healthy but very tired of the war and eager for news from home: he had heard none since the battle of Shiloh.

Velasco lies east of the river and Quintana west. Most troops and headquarters are at Quintana. Velasco has only five or six houses, and Quintana about twice as many. The two "cities" face each other across about three hundred yards of river. There is no bay at the mouth. A fort stands on each side, right on the beach, covering the channel.

Scan 117 09-117

A schooner founders off Velasco

During the night there was considerable rain and a strong northeast wind. Two schooners were loaded to sail. One started out and struck the steamboat with her bow, damaging the *[[bow?]]* and a chimney. The schooner broke the main chain between her cutwater and bowsprit, but the crew did not notice until she reached the sea.

In deep water and heavy swells, she sprang a leak and had to return. The crew worked the pumps, but water entered so fast that she sank less than half a mile from shore, inside the outer bar on the sheltered side of the channel. The sea was too rough for the crew to leave before daylight, even though water washed over the decks.

At dawn, three men set out in the schooner's only small boat. Four remained *[[in the rigging?]]*, none able to swim. The boat soon capsized in the breakers. *[[One?]]* man let go and swam ashore; the other

[[two?]] held onto the boat and drifted ashore four miles [[down?]] the beach.

The waves were so high that no boat could leave shore to help the men on the schooner, though they were less than half a mile away. Only a lifeboat could have survived in such a sea.

Reading note. The source clips many line beginnings. Bracketed words flag uncertain details; surrounding sentences are modernized from the surviving text.

Scan 118 09-118

Men stranded in the rigging; George returns to Houston

The nearest lifeboat was at the wreck of the *Acacia*, ten miles upwind along the beach. No boat could be launched into the open sea in such a gale. When our boat left, nothing had been done for the men clinging to the ropes. Without an available lifeboat, nothing could be done. I had never seen such rough seas and hope never to see them again with a vessel in distress.

They could not be taken off until the sea calmed. By Saturday morning the wind came from the north. If they had not fallen from exhaustion, they were probably rescued then. But two nights and a day was a long time to cling to ropes while the vessel rocked in the sand with every swell and threatened to break apart.

On Friday I returned to Columbia in rain and unpleasant cold. Rain continued through Friday night and Saturday. I reached Houston on Saturday night and found deep, thin mud. Wharton's death had caused an uproar, but everything was quiet again.

All are well here. We have no orders to leave yet. There is a rumor that transportation has been ordered for 30,000 men.

George [[surname partly clipped]].

Scan 119 09-119

Sabine Pass, April 25: a burst cannon and uncertain battle reports

Sabine Pass, April 25, year unstated. Letter 18.

I received your number 9, and [[Laura's?]] number 8 at the same time. I wrote to you the other day. Your letter was mailed on the 4th—twenty-one days ago, a long time for a letter within the state. Henry [[Mundwell?]] arrived two days ago. He says Warren will not leave for camp before May 1.

I described the skirmish in my last letter. There has been no hostile movement since. Five Federals came ashore the other night and drove our cavalry sentries into town—or rather, the sentries became frightened and came in of their own accord.

A serious accident occurred on Thursday. The Bell's 64-pound rifled cannon burst during practice, killing two men and wounding two. It matched the gun that burst on the Bayou City on the morning of the Galveston fight.

Reports continue to say Sibley was defeated at New Iberia, though I have seen no published account. They claim 250 were killed and that he is under arrest for being drunk during the battle. Another rumor says the Yankees have taken Alexandria, Louisiana—

Scan 120 09-120

Orders for western Louisiana and beef too lean for gravy

—and have thirty thousand men. I do not know how much is true. What I do know is that Colonel Griffin received orders yesterday from General Scurry to hold his available force ready to march to western

Louisiana at a moment's notice. The order was read at dress parade yesterday evening. Today they are listing all the company's guns and cartridge boxes. I suppose they are getting *[[anxious?]]* to start. For all the difference it makes, I would as soon go to western Louisiana as stay here.

I think our health would be better if they kept us on the island all the time. There is little illness in camp apart from mostly mild mumps. Our main food is cornbread and "blue beef." I have seen plenty of beef so lean that boiling a whole kettle of it thoroughly left not one drop of grease on the water. It is improving now: sometimes we can make a little gravy, a great improvement.

Separate names and marks above the text: *[[A. B. Henry?]]*, *[[P. Cox?]]*, *[[J. Shackelford?]]*, and tally marks.

Scan 121 09-121

George returns to Galveston, May 4, 1865

Galveston, May 4, 1865. Sister Lizzie,

We have moved here since I last wrote. Yesterday we left our old quarters after breakfast, traveled by special train, and settled into the new quarters in time for supper. In fine weather, it was our most pleasant move yet.

On May 2, Colonel Spaight reviewed us, and we marched through central Houston in platoon columns. O'Brien's company was absent, so we were at the regiment's left, or "tail," following a Creole company that could not keep its line, step, or distance. This did little for our appearance. Several women came out, but there was little enthusiasm: scarcely a waved handkerchief and no cheers. One teenage girl looked eager to do something. I raised my hat and she bowed politely. I attracted no more notice.

Many citizens regretted our departure. Prominent people tried to persuade Magruder to let us stay, but he refused. On the morning we left, the citizens gave the regiment a box of tobacco and 620 pounds of coffee. Some even said they would pay each man in Company C ten dollars a month in coin to keep us there. That shows our standing after five months in Houston.

The reason for the move is simple. Magruder wants Ashbel Smith to command Galveston Island—*[[the final name is partly clipped; the next page explains]]*.

Scan 122 09-122

Schoolhouse quarters, a sea bath, and reports of surrender

—but Elmore outranked Smith as colonel and had to be moved. Spaight was the only colonel in the subdistrict junior to Smith, so we came to accommodate Smith.

Our company has plenty of room in the Robb Schoolhouse, with no other company sharing it and none closer than a block away. It is a pleasant spot in the southern part of the city, a little over half a mile from the South Battery and about half a mile from our former quarters on Strand Street. It is on the east side of the street from Smith's garden to the customs house and market, about three blocks from the customs house. Jody will know it.

Today I enjoyed a roll in the salt water and swallowed a little in the process. A blockading ship lay close enough for me to see men on deck and its dark gunports, but they left us alone. There are twelve vessels in the fleet. There was a flag of truce today; I have heard no result yet.

The Wren arrived the night before last with cannon, ammunition, and New York news through April 22. The reports say Johnson and Beauregard surrendered on the same terms as Lee. There must be something to it, since the blockading fleet fired a salute recently. Today I heard that news had arrived which the authorities would not allow to be published.

I received a letter this evening from *[[Doc H?]]*, dated April *[[28?]]*. He was unwell. I will write again once we are better settled. Supper is almost ready, so I must stop. Excuse the haste. Affectionately, George. All are well in camp.

Scan 123 09-123

A damaged and deserted Galveston, May 7, 1865

Galveston, Texas, May 7, 1865. Sister Lizzie,

Your letter of April 22 arrived last evening. One letter must be missing, since the correspondence does not quite connect. I think I forgot what I promised to tell you after returning from Velasco. It was only that Jody might go home; at that point it was still a prospect.

The captain says to tell Jody not to hurry back and to get what he went for, if possible. No one has come in, so he cannot give an extension of time. Jody will not be expected before June 1, and not especially then unless transportation is convenient.

Galveston has suffered badly. Signs of rough treatment are everywhere. It is much less attractive than two years ago, though still prettier than Houston. Business has stopped and the city looks deserted. Most wealthier residents have left. Poor people remain without employment; I cannot tell how they survive. I have seen no money circulating. Business is in Houston, while Galveston is neglected and forgotten. Several regiments are quartered all over the city. Wherever they have stayed, they have ruined the houses. The Tremont House and Island City Hotel are worthless. Fences and old houses have been burned for fuel wherever an excuse could be found. Magruder has filled this end of the island with ditches and holes, ruining the landscape. An uninterrupted breastwork runs from the South Battery to Fort *[[Scurry?]]* and farther than I know. Lieutenant Colonel Bankhead ordered the sandhills between the battery and fort leveled, but the wind is rapidly rebuilding them. *[[The last line is clipped; it refers to a street near the courthouse.]]*

Scan 124 09-124

Rumors that the war is over—and George's explicit caution

Now for the news. Rumors are numerous and varied. At least this seems clear: Johnston has surrendered, or is so close that he cannot avoid it. You may know as much of the details as I do.

Behind the scenes, there have been rumors of unpublished news. Flake of the Bulletin admitted as much. I have heard a little: Colonel Wilkes has arrived on parole from New Orleans. According to him, Sherman and Johnston agreed that Johnston would surrender Confederate forces everywhere, place their weapons in state arsenals, disband the troops, and send them home. State governments, laws, and officers would remain, but renounce the Confederacy, renew allegiance to the United States, and return to the Union. He says a forty-day armistice was arranged to consult the Washington cabinet, which rejected the proposal because it recognized state governments. He also reports that Grant would support Sherman with his army, treating the agreement as a military surrender approved by Breckenridge and Davis. That is the story, if my information is correct.

Warren told me this, and he is not one to jump to such a conclusion. He believes the war is over and the news is being withheld until official orders tell this department to give up and go home, allowing the change to happen quietly. If this is not premature, a couple of months will finish the drama. Much may be getting ahead of the facts, but the mystery around the published accounts encourages speculation. Wilkes also brings unpublished news that Stoneman raided Johnson's rear and destroyed immense

quantities of supplies, railroads, and bridges. Take all this for what it is worth: I cannot vouch *[[for its correctness; the last line is partly lost]]*.

Scan 125 09-125

February 26, 1865: sore eyes, spring weather, and Confederate money

Houston, February 26, 1865. Sister Lizzie,

Your letter of the 11th arrived a day or two ago. I am glad your sore eyes have recovered. My own limited experience shows how unpleasant they are, though fortunately they have troubled me little so far.

The past week brought both fair and foul weather, with considerable rain overall. Friday and Friday night were very wet, but Saturday was fine and the mud is drying quickly today. I think spring has begun here.

There may be a few cold days yet, but I expect none severe enough to cause harm.

Prices are slightly higher than last week. Confederate money has risen to “25” *[[the exchange basis is unstated]]*, with little circulating. There seems to be an effort to reduce its circulation. Restoring its value would be an extraordinary achievement. I think only uncompromising *[[tyranny?]]* under military supervision could make it good again—and we will get plenty of that in the coming year, in every form to suit those providing it.

Scan 126 09-126

George mocks appeals to “military necessity” and unlimited sacrifice

There is little war news this week. Since peace prospects collapsed, no important fighting has been reported. Very little truth gets out nowadays, probably because Confederate affairs east of the Mississippi are so precarious.

We supposedly have freedom of conscience, speech, and the press under military *[[despotism?]]*. They are certainly “under” it—buried so deeply that they may never get out. So be it! It is amusing to watch states’ rights and every other defense of liberty patched up and excused as “military necessity.” Anyone who complains about government action is called unpatriotic whenever its final purpose is said to be worthy.

By that reasoning, any means become proper, just, and even praiseworthy if they accomplish the smallest good. A “good patriot” must surrender property, produce, and personal freedom to the government “for the time being” to achieve the “glorious end” of Southern independence. The last *[[woman?]]* and child must be sacrificed on liberty’s altar rather than accept Yankee rule; annihilation is supposedly preferable to such “slavery.” Anyone who will not give everything is called a coward and a scoundrel. That is the spirit of today’s fire-eating press.

Reading note. George is criticizing these arguments through irony; the extreme language is not an instruction or endorsement.

Scan 127 09-127

The loudest war advocates—and an unkind assessment of city fashions

Brave editors behind desks, brave legislators in Congress, brave old men smoking by the fireplace, and brave boys too young for conscription can talk about what “we’ll do” to the Yankees and how long “we’ll fight.” Men who have never smelled gunpowder and never will are ready to fight longer than anyone else. Those who talk most about fighting do none of it. Some patriotic firebrands who promised to spill the “last drop of blood” unknowingly spoke the truth: they will be the last to spill any blood.

I went to the Methodist Episcopal church today. It was full of soldiers, civilians, and women. To me, this city seems to have more unattractive women than anywhere I have been. I cannot remember seeing a handsome one here. They spoil their appearance with excessive clothing and fashionable touches that suggest a *[[soft?]]* spot in the brain. Their love of novelty—or vanity—and desire to display something new and attract attention do not suit me. It reminds me of Burns: if some power gave us the gift of seeing ourselves as others see us, it would spare us many a blunder and foolish notion.

Scan 128 09-128

Children playing bring George's childhood to mind

6 p.m. This evening I walked through the western part of the city. Compared with the business district, it made an interesting picture. Everything was quiet, with people in their Sunday clothes. Some walked in the mild spring air and sunshine, but most sat together in their attractive parlors, apparently enjoying themselves.

Comfortable cottages and their associations with home are pleasant to see, even if I cannot enjoy them myself now. Merry children playing on sunny slopes and grassy lawns reminded me of fondly remembered days. Those scenes cannot return, but similar sights keep them fresh in memory. Nothing recalls the past as quickly as a group of happy children.

The church bell is ringing, and I intend to go. I will finish and mail this so it can leave tomorrow. I do not remember Miss Luna or Kate *[[Denny?]]*, but I do remember Miss Lizzie K. Tell the girls to enjoy themselves while they are young; when they are old, perhaps they cannot.

With love to all, your brother, George.

Scan 129 09-129

Houston, December 11, 1864: yellow fever and church music

Houston, December 11, 1864. Sister Lizzie,

Your letter of November 19 has arrived. It found everyone well in body and mind, as far as I can judge. We have had plenty of cool and some cold weather this week. I think it is enough to clear the city of yellow fever unless the weather changes again *[[part of the phrase is obscured]]*.

There has been much fever lately, confined to civilians' houses. Among people returning since the November 20 freeze, cases have occurred only in houses where it had been during summer. I am not afraid of an outbreak among the troops, since we occupy houses without cases this season.

This morning I attended the Methodist church. Neither preacher nor sermon was exceptional, and the congregation was small for a city. An organ stood in one corner. A large Black man worked its pumping handle while a woman skillfully played the keys.

Reading note. The account preserves George's understanding of yellow fever at the time; it is not a modern explanation of transmission.

Scan 130 09-130

George compares Methodist and Episcopal worship

To me, instrumental music is as out of place in church as a dog in a parlor. I felt I was at a sermon until the organ began; then it seemed like a party. I cannot find support in the New Testament for music in churches—unless it hides in some corner I have overlooked.

Last Sunday I attended the Episcopal church. It is a large, magnificent brick building in Gothic style,

which I associate with Catholic churches. The minister emerged from a side room in a robe, knelt for private prayer where everyone could see him, and began the service. Minister and congregation alternated reading verses aloud, and the congregation repeated his prayer sentences. They sang psalms instead of hymns. These sounded very good, with some variation in tune but perfect harmony.

Afterward the younger members were questioned on the catechism to assess their progress toward full membership, including reciting the creed. I consider the creed identical to the Presbyterians' *[[the next words are obscured]]*, and very good if they practice what they preach.

Infants are baptized with two sponsors who promise to raise them, or ensure they are properly and religiously raised, if their parents die or cannot care for them. There is much ceremony, resembling Catholic worship. The preaching is fairly plain, but I dislike the fashion and display around it.

I largely agree with Fanny Fern: "True religion may go to Church in yellow gloves—"

Scan 131 09-131

Wealth, religious display, and George's preference for modest dress

"—and embroidered handkerchiefs worth five hundred dollars, but I don't believe it!" Still, I do not know that I have any right to judge Houston's people simply because they are wealthy.

I have noticed several new styles of women's hats. I prefer high-crowned, narrow-brimmed leghorn hats to the broad-brimmed styles once so conspicuous on the prairies. Even so, in my opinion the old-fashioned close "split" bonnet is the prettiest thing a woman ever wore on her head.

You may call that outdated in an age of showy display, when brilliance is all the *[[rage?]]*. But it is modest, and I consider modesty a woman's finest quality, whatever the world says. Above all, be modest.

Scan 132 09-132

Auctions, flour supplies, and Sherman's move into Georgia

Sunday, December 11, 7 p.m. I am writing by candlelight again, adding a few thoughts in my usual disconnected way. The boys are going to the Methodist church, leaving me alone. It is too cold for me to go unless they abandon the music and provide preaching instead of entertainment.

There are auctions almost daily, offering nearly every kind of dry goods at very high, though slightly falling, prices. Flour is plentiful wholesale and retail, in quantities to suit buyers. Asked where it comes from, people always say "up the country." I have not heard of much being sold to civilians there; I thought the government took it all for the army.

The latest news is somewhat stirring. Sherman has made a bold move into Georgia, surprising everyone and causing excitement in military circles. For once, he has outmaneuvered Hood and all his advisers.

[[The final words are clipped.]]

Scan 133 09-133

Guarded soldiers' opinions, private gossip, and expected emancipation

The report that Magruder was ordered back to Texas is wrong. It is strange how people who should know better start and believe such rumors. Walker will remain in command, and furloughs will continue as usual. Spaight is trying to recall everyone on detached duty. With all present, the regiment would number nearly a thousand, making it about the largest in the state.

About a dozen men from our company are home on leave. Only one has married so far: according to reports, the old bachelor Eddings married a widow in *[[Stewart?]]* a few days ago. He has not returned.

You were somewhat mistaken at “Shialot” about the war question. Soldiers generally profess more patriotism than they feel because they do not know whom they are dealing with and prefer to be safe. As for the marriage matter, I was very surprised. Although I often act by fits and starts, this one stumped me. I did not know that she had done anything disreputable. I heard Henry had renounced his intentions, but thought it was a lovers’ matter. What else I heard only confirmed an old opinion about a lack of moral courage and resolve. I know no more than I knew three years ago about what has happened since I left home or entered service, and I do not care to know. Let the subject drop. *[[He?]]* had better forget marriage and go to Mexico to escape these troubled times. Black people are bound to be freed before the war ends, and Jeff will not give up while he can get a white or Black man to fight for him. “Mr. Southern is something by himself.”

Scan 134 09-134

Blockade running, conscription, and a cold room

A schooner has just reached the bayou landing from Tampico with merchandise. It belongs to *[[Reichman?]]* and Myers of this city.

Many people along the coast avoid service through blockade running, though they do not sail on the vessels themselves. A few men are gathering conscripts and sending them to the front. They should instead collect idle, useless officers and put them where they belong, rather than trouble honest men. It is late and cold, and our room has no fire, so I will close. I must take this to the post office tonight so it can leave for Millican in the morning.

With love to all, your brother, George Douglas.